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CONDEMNING CORRUPTION, LIVING WITH IT

A mixed-methods exploration of the layered nature of corruption tolerance and the role of system justification

Chiara Lenti

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Supervisor:	Florence So
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Abstract

Despite widespread moral condemnation, corruption often ends up being tolerated. Intending to contribute to the literature seeking to understand what mechanisms might help explain this apparent paradox, this thesis explores corruption tolerance (CT) through the lens of System Justification Theory (SJT), a social psychological framework underutilised within corruption research. Under SJT, individuals might come to justify systems that disadvantage them, either through active endorsement of the status quo or through more subtle and passive forms of system justification (SJ).

Recognising CT as a multidimensional phenomenon, the study adopts a recently developed typology of CT developed by (Bravo et al., 2025) that distinguishes between normative, attitudinal, practical, intentional and behavioral tolerance. A cross-sectional mixed-methods online survey design was employed. Quantitative analysis primarily examined the relationship between General System Justification (GSJ) and multiple dimensions of CT, alongside additional exploratory analyses of related factors. Qualitative responses were integrated and used to explore broader patterns and narratives surrounding corruption, particularly in relation to emotional responses associated with it. Although SJT served as the primary analytical lens, all throughout the process, the study remained attentive to alternative and complementary explanations discussed in the literature. Italy, a country characterised by widespread moral condemnation of corruption yet seemingly stubborn persistence of it, was chosen as a theoretically relevant context in which to explore these mechanisms.

Findings supported the importance of approaching CT as a multidimensional and context-sensitive phenomenon. While quantitative results provided limited evidence for GSJ as a direct predictor of CT, qualitative answers pointed towards patterns consistent with more passive forms of SJ, characterised by feelings of powerlessness and resignation in the face of a system that appears inevitable and too difficult to change.

Due to limitations tied to the sample size and representativeness, results should be interpreted with caution and no causal claims are made. While the study remains primarily exploratory in nature, it points to the potential relevance of emotional processes in shaping CT and underscores the value of integrating qualitative approaches into future research.

Keywords: corruption tolerance, system justification theory, multidimensionality, emotional processes, mixed methods

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about this thesis. It is finally over.*

Abbreviations

Corruption experience (CE)

Corruption perception (CP)

Corruption tolerance (CT)

General System Justification (GSJ)

System Justification Theory (SJT)

System Justification (SJ)

Social Identity Theory (SIT)

Social Dominance Theory (SDT)

Corruption tolerance (CT)

Transparency International (TI)

Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB)

AI declaration

Over the course of this process AI was strictly used as a support tool in line with the Programme's requirements. It was not employed to generate text or replace independent analytical work. All conceptual decisions, interpretations of findings and written content remain my own. The primary use concerned support with the quantitative component of the study. As a student with limited background in statistical analysis, alongside sources such as video tutorials and material provided by my own supervisor, Chat GPT helped support coding in Stata, troubleshooting and statistical clarifications. AI was also occasionally used for translation purposes (from Italian to English). This had the sole function of improving efficiency, and translations were thoroughly double-checked and revised when necessary. Lastly, especially towards the end of the process, AI tools like Grammarly and ChatGPT were used for suggestions on how to polish language and detection of spelling mistakes.

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1. Introduction

Even though most people around the world tend to condemn corruption, we seem to be unable to get rid of it. This puzzle, commonly addressed through the concept of corruption tolerance (CT), is widely documented in the literature.

Vignette experiments and surveys repeatedly show that although respondents express disapproval of corruption, they are often willing to tolerate it, whether that be by engaging in corruption themselves, by continuing to support corrupt incumbents or by passively not acting against it (Agerberg, 2022; Erlingsson & Kristinsson, 2018; Gouvêa Maciel, 2021; Pozsgai-Alvarez, 2022).

Why does corruption persist even where it is widely regarded as wrong? Scholars have put forward many explanations, drawing on theoretical traditions that span from principal-agent models (Groenendijk, 1997), collective action approaches (Persson et al., 2013), and, more recently, cognitive and behavioral perspectives emphasizing the role of norms (N. C. Köbis et al., 2018), as well as psychological and social mechanisms such as moral disengagement and in-group bias (Takacs Haynes & Rašković, 2021).

While our understanding of the phenomenon has undoubtedly gone forward, important aspects remain underexplored. A recent critical interpretive synthesis (CIS) by (Bravo et al., 2025) has highlighted two important limitations. First, CT is often poorly defined, and the field lacks an appropriate conceptual framework that allows to account for its multidimensionality. Second, emotional processes are largely absent from how CT is conceptualized and studied, which an omission that deserves further attention, given the central role of emotions in shaping judgments, reasonings and behavior (Bravo et al., 2025, p. 8).

Adding to mainstream theoretical approaches found in the literature, this thesis argues that System Justification Theory (SJT) offers a promising framework for addressing this gap. Under an SJT framework, individuals have a psychological motivation to maintain existing social and political arrangements - even when they are disadvantaged by them - because doing so helps them manage negative emotions that would be associated with challenging the status quo (J. T. Jost, 2019).

Opting for a cross-sectional mixed-method survey design conducted in Italy, which provides a theoretically relevant case due to the coexistence of widespread moral commendation of corruption and continued corruption persistence, this study explores whether and to what extent SJT can help explain different forms of CT, while also accounting for other explanations discussed in the literature.

The study offers two main contributions. Theoretically, it applies SJT to the study of CT, an approach that remains relatively underexplored in corruption research and that allows to address the emotional and affective dimensions of tolerance highlighted by (Bravo et al., 2025). Methodologically, it adopts (Bravo et al., 2025)'s multidimensional framework, allowing for different forms of CT to be analyzed

in the same sample. By combining quantitative and qualitative components and considering alternative explanatory approaches alongside SJT, the study also strives to highlight the value of employing holistic approaches as well as the integration of qualitative components in the study of CT.

The remainder of the thesis is structured as follows. Section 2 reviews the broader literature on corruption before narrowing the focus on the concept of CT. Section 3 summarizes what discussed and presents the gap and research questions the thesis aims to address. Section 4 reviews SJT, starting with a brief account of its origins and its core assumptions, followed by a reflection on why it may matter for the study of CT. Section 5 presents the research design and addresses methodological choices, including the rationale behind the choice of a mixed-method survey design, operationalization of key concepts and limitations. Section 6 presents the results, starting with the main quantitative component, followed by supplementary quantitative analysis, and lastly, the qualitative results. Section 7 discusses the results in light of the broader literature and theoretical framework. Finally, Section 8 concludes by highlighting main findings and contributions.

2. Literature review

To situate CT within broader debates on corruption, the review starts by discussing how definitions shape the way corruption is perceived and studied and then moves to broader debates concerning causes, consequences and prevention of corruption. Building on this foundation, attention shifts to CT, touching upon the confusion surrounding its conceptualization, the factors associated with it and the main theoretical approaches used to explain it.

2.1 How do we define corruption?

Despite the existence of a rather large body of literature on corruption, there is no single, universally accepted definition of the concept (Rose, 2018, p. 220).

Complications tied to finding a definition are partly due to the hidden, context-dependent, and evolving nature of corrupt practices, which make corruption difficult to observe and measure (Bautista-Beauchesne & Garzon, 2019, p. 736). At the same time, they are also in part related to the intrinsically moral dimension of corruption, which complicates efforts to formulate a value-neutral definition (Rose, 2018, p. 222).

Notwithstanding these complications, there is one formulation, which one could argue represents some sort of pragmatic compromise. Transparency International's (TI) definition of corruption as "the abuse of entrusted power for private gain" (TI, 2026) is arguably the most common definition used by scholars and policymakers alike (Rose, 2018, p. 221).

This kind of definition has its perks, such as clarity and empirical applicability, but has also been criticized for its limited scope, as it is very much tied to the public sector and risks overlooking other forms of corruption (Julius Otusanya, 2011a, p. 389). So, while it remains useful, corruption remains best understood as a "complex set of processes involving human behavior and many other variables, some of which are difficult to recognize or measure" (Zakiuddin & Haque, 2002 p.5) (Julius Otusanya, 2011, p. 389).

In absence of a suitable single definition, it has been very common to rely on classifications. A commonly used distinction differentiates between *petty* and *grand* corruption, based on the scale of resources involved and the level of authority of the actors engaging in corrupt behavior (Alvarez-García et al., 2025, p. 3). Another influential classification is (Heidenheimer, 1970)'s distinction between *black*, *grey* and *white* corruption, which provides a categorization that is based on the levels of acceptance showcased by elites and ordinary citizens towards a corrupt act (Alvarez-García et al., 2025, p. 3). While black corruption is broadly condemned by both groups, white corruption refers to acts considered tolerable, with grey corruption occupying an intermediate position. The existence of this typology

underscores that corruption is not uniformly rejected and already hints at the concept of CT, suggesting that some practices may be normalized or ignored in given contexts (Alvarez-García et al., 2025, p. 3).

As hinted already, the conceptual ambiguity and the elusive nature of corruption have another important implication: measurement becomes quite hard. As a solution, scholars and international organizations rely on *perceptions* of corruption as a proxy. While practical, this fix introduces an additional challenge, as perceptions are far from being unbiased and are likely shaped by individual's values and understanding of what corruption entails (Oliveira Leite et al., 2021, p. 164).

In fact, it is not only scholars who tend to have different ways to define what corruption is: the wider public is confronted with the same difficulty (Rose, 2018, p. 230). Different people have different *conceptualizations* of corruption: what might be regarded as corrupt by someone might not be seen in the same light by someone else.

In this regard, a study by (navot & beeri, 2018) indicates that perceptions of political corruption are significantly driven by an individual's conceptual framework: those with broader, more moralistic conceptions of corruption tend to perceive higher levels of corruption, while more restrictive, law-based views lead to lower perception (navot and beeri, 2018, p. 106). In a very similar way, (Clemente et al., 2024, p. 627) distinguish between people holding what they define as a *minimalist* (strictly law-based) vs a *maximalist* (ethics-based) definition of corruption, with the former being connected to perceiving less corruption compared to the latter. Other elements, including sociodemographic factors, such as gender and religiosity, as well as individual's moral identity have proven to affect people's understanding of what corruption is and therefore perceptions of corruption (Oliveira Leite et al., 2021, p. 183).

In sum, studies show that individual predispositions, values, norms and culture can affect what people define as corruption. Understanding these differences is important, because perception of corruption can have an impact on a series of other factors (navot & beeri, 2018), including system support (Linde & Erlingsson, 2011), the likelihood of detection and reporting (Clemente et al., 2024, p. 627) and, as one of the next sections will elaborate on, possibly also on CT.

2.2 Corruption research: causes, consequences and prevention

Aside from trying to define what it is, the study of corruption has mainly been concerned with three other aspects: why it occurs, what consequences it has, and how those consequences can be tamed.

Scholars have approached these questions using a wide range of theoretical frameworks (Julius Otusanya, 2011, p. 393). At the individual level, these have included public choice and rational choice perspectives conceptualizing corruption as the outcome of strategic decisions by self-interested individuals (Rose-Ackerman, 1978), or “bad apple” theories attributing corruption to personal moral

deficiencies (De Graaf, 2007, pp. 49–50). Moving beyond the micro level, organizational culture approaches emphasize the role of workplace norms (De Graaf, 2007, pp. 52–53), while broader moral values theories similarly highlight how prevailing norms and value systems can influence conduct, potentially normalizing corrupt behavior under certain cultural conditions (Rose-Ackerman, 1999). Lastly, more correlational-based approaches examine the association between corruption and specific political, economic or institutional factors (De Graaf, 2007, pp. 59–62).

When it comes to the study of the consequences of corruption, contrary to what one might think, scholars have not always unequivocally declared it bad for the welfare of society (Julius Otusanya, 2011, p. 395). Early contributions have argued for potential benefits to economic development under certain conditions. From this perspective, corruption was seen as a mechanism to allocate scarce resources, facilitating investments, or even strengthening the private sector (Nye, 1967; Julius Otusanya, 2011, p. 395). These arguments are often referred to as the “grease the wheels” hypothesis, where corruption compensates for institutional deficiencies (Jong-A-Pin & Bjørnskov, 2025). Later research has clearly challenged this idea. Countless studies now show that corruption leads to bad economic performance and negatively affects development by entrenching poverty and exacerbating inequality (Julius Otusanya, 2011, p. 404). By eroding citizens’ trust in public officials, corruption weakens voluntary compliance, leads to less tax income and diminishes public service provision (Rose, 2018, p. 220).

Taken together, current literature largely converges on the conclusion that corruption is harmful and that we should strive to get rid of it. Unsurprisingly, much scholarly work on the topic has been devoted precisely to this (World Bank Group, 2026). Within this broader branch of literature, research has prioritized reactive approaches aimed at detecting and punishing corruption, however the study of corruption *prevention* is also gaining traction (Bautista-Beauchesne and Garzon, 2019, p. 729). Within this latter branch, a key distinction is made between studies focusing on *normative prevention*, aimed at changing norms and values normalizing corruption, and *legalistic prevention*, which aims at modifying rules to bring about change (Bautista-Beauchesne and Garzon, 2019, p. 734). Although legalistic measures are important, scholars increasingly recognize that their effectiveness is limited if corrupt practices continue to be socially tolerated.

In fact, recent research highlights the importance of low public tolerance in deterring corrupt behavior (Bautista-Beauchesne & Garzon, 2019, p. 733). At the same time, empirical evidence also reveals a striking tension: most citizens seem to *already* condemn corruption, yet in practice they often end up tolerating it (Agerberg, 2022; Erlingsson & Kristinsson, 2018; Gouvêa Maciel, 2021; Pozsgai-Alvarez, 2022). This disconnect between expressed moral opposition to corruption and continued tolerance constitutes a norm-practice paradox that lies at the heart of the debate on CT.

Ultimately, understanding CT becomes crucial not only for understanding better corruption itself, but also for developing more effective prevention strategies and have a real chance at eradicating it. The next section turns directly to the concept of CT and the factors associated with it.

2.3 The study of corruption tolerance

After briefly touching upon how CT has been defined and operationalized in the literature, CT is situated in relation to related concepts of corruption experience (CE) and corruption perception (CP). Lastly, the influence of both individual and contextual factors on levels of CT are highlighted.

2.3.1 Conceptualizing corruption tolerance

Since there is no single definition of corruption, it might not come as a surprise that there is no single definition of CT either (Alvarez-García et al., 2025, p. 3). However, broadly speaking, one can understand it as (Alvarez-García et al., 2025, p.3) do in their study by relying on a definition proposed by (Moreno, 2002, p. 497) according to which CT is “the extent to which individuals tend to justify certain practices that can be considered to be corrupt”.

In practice, when studying CT few authors precisely define what it means, and those that do, do it in different ways, creating a lot of confusion (Bravo et al., 2025). Terms such as “tolerance”, “permissiveness” or “acceptance” of corruption have all been used interchangeably to broadly mean the same thing (Gouvêa Maciel, 2021, p. 1132). The result is that CT has been used in the literature to capture a wide range of behaviors and attitudes, ranging from active participation in corruption (Pozsgai-Alvarez, 2022), the act of voting for corrupt incumbents (Charron & Bågenholm, 2025), to more passive forms, such as mere inaction in the face of the phenomenon (Fleming et al., 2022).

What is important to keep in mind is that talking of CT means that we are not only interested in the act of corruption, but we also want to understand the attitude and likelihood of someone engaging in the act (Pozsgai-Alvarez, 2022, p. 383). More precisely, CT should be viewed as a process, the starting point being a) a set of conditions, b) how they are perceived by the individual, c) attitude formation, and, finally, d) a behavioral response (Pozsgai-Alvarez, 2022, p. 383).

Responding to calls for greater conceptual clarity, (Bravo et al., 2025) recently published a paper that critiques unidimensional approaches to CT and that highlights underexplored dimensions of the phenomenon.

More precisely, the authors develop a typology-based model based on the Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB) (Ajzen, 1991) that delineates five types or dimensions of tolerance: attitudinal, normative, practical, intentional, and behavioral (Bravo et al., 2025, p. 12) .

Table 1 (Bravo et al., 2025)'s typology of corruption tolerance

TPB component	Corruption tolerance dimension	Description
Attitude toward behavior	Attitudinal tolerance	Degree of support or opposition to corrupt practices
Subjective norm	Normative tolerance	Perceived social acceptance of corruption
Perceived behavioral control	Practical tolerance	Tolerance arising from perceived feasibility or constraints
Behavioral intention	Intentional tolerance	Declared willingness to engage in corrupt practices
Behavior	Behavioral tolerance	Tolerance expressed through concrete behavior

Note: adapted from (Bravo et al., 2025, p. 12)

The typology clearly showcases the process-like nature of CT and allows to account for the multiple ways in which tolerance can emerge. At the same time, (Bravo et al., 2025, p. 8) note that several other aspects remain underexplored, and not all possible dimensions of the phenomenon are accounted for through the typology they propose. In particular, while studies have mostly approached corruption tolerance cognitively or from a behavioral perspective, little attention has been paid to the affective dimension, and the role emotional responses may play in shaping tolerance. Put in better words: not many studies look at how people *feel* about corruption, and little is known about how individuals emotionally react to corruption and the role such emotional responses might have in shaping tolerance.

This gap is particularly relevant for this study, but before delving more into it in Section 3, the review first touches upon other factors that existing research has frequently linked to CT.

2.3.2 Corruption experience, perception and tolerance

The literature suggests that both CE and CP levels are associated with CT. Multiple studies show that greater *exposure* to corruption is linked to higher levels of tolerance towards it (Gouvêa Maciel, 2021; Hunady, 2017; Alvarez-García et al., 2025, p. 18). Similarly, other studies contain some proof that higher levels of *perceived* corruption tend to be associated with greater CT (Cameron et al., 2009; Keller & Sik, 2009).

However, these relationships are neither uniform nor particularly strong. (Megías et al., 2023) for instance shows that in Portugal high perceived corruption is accompanied by a high intolerance to corruption (Alvarez-García et al., 2025, p. 4). Another good example is (Cameron et al., 2009), who find contrasting results within the same study. Based on their results, while India and Australia provide some evidence in favor of the argument that greater exposure can build tolerance, their results from

Singapore and Indonesia do not go in the same direction (Cameron et al., 2009, p. 850). Moreover, they find differences in propensities to *punish* corrupt behavior and propensities to *engage* in corrupt behavior, highlighting that operationalization choices likely affect results.

Relatedly, in studying the influence of high levels of corruption on CT, (Pop, 2012) puts forwards two possible scenarios: first, that it might lead to more CT, because feeling as though corruption is part of everyday life reframes the behavior as something normal; second, that it might lead to more intolerance, because experiencing corruption and the injustice that comes along with it increases the chances of developing a strong negative evaluation of corruption (Alvarez-García et al., 2025, p. 4). Interestingly, she ends up not being able to rule in favor of either one of the hypotheses, explaining that a possible reason for that is that “the two mechanisms work at the same time, or they work differentially for different population groups, overall cancelling themselves out” (Pop, 2012, p. 39).

This all suggests that generalizations about the relationship between corruption experience, perception and tolerance are of limited value. Instead, cultural (Cameron et al., 2009) and individual-level factors (Megías et al., 2023; Pop, 2012) appear to play a crucial role in shaping both the extent to which individuals tolerate corruption and the mechanisms through which this tolerance emerges.

2.3.3 Micro and macro factors affecting corruption tolerance

Several authors have shown that individual characteristics such as age, gender or educational level can influence people’s CT (Alvarez-García et al., 2025, p. 3).

For example, at the individual level, (Pop, 2012, p. 37) finds gender and religiosity to be the most predictive factors, with being a woman and religious significantly reducing the likelihood approving corruption. She also finds that young individuals with no occupation have a higher likelihood of accepting corruption compared to people having partners or children.

Contextual factors also appear to matter. In her study, (Pop, 2012, p. 38) also shows that countries that were part of the former Soviet Bloc have been found to be more tolerant, thereby highlighting that the broader cultural and institutional context also matter. The cultural argument is also present in (Cameron et al., 2009, p. 850-851), who hypothesize that their ambivalent findings in India, Australia, Singapore and Indonesia are likely due to the countries’ respective recent institutional histories.

(Gouvêa Maciel, 2021) go as far as creating a broad description of the profiles of three types of citizens who tend to tolerate corruption, highlighting how socio-economic factors as well as political attitudes jointly shape tolerance (Gouvêa Maciel, 2021, p. 1147). The same goes for (Mazzoleni, 2008, p. 55), who shows that lower education level, a right leaning political view and higher political trust people are more reluctant to condemn corrupt politicians.

Beyond socio-demographic and contextual factors, (Megías et al., 2023, p. 22) find that individuals with a more deontological approach to ethics (process oriented) rather than a consequentialist one (outcome oriented) are more prone to be intolerant towards corruption. Moreover, while being satisfied with life is linked to more intolerant positions, economic precariousness increased the chances of being more tolerant towards corruption (Megías et al., 2023, p. 23).

Overall, research on CP and CE has advanced our understanding of the conditions under which CT is more likely to emerge. Socio-demographic factors, (Gouvêa Maciel, 2021, p. 1147); individual morality (Clemente et al., 2024) and understanding of ethics (Megías et al., 2023, p. 22); contextual factors such as life satisfaction and economic insecurity (Megías et al., 2023, p. 23) as well as the broader cultural, historical (Cameron et al., 2009, pp. 850–851; Pop, 2012, p. 38) and political context, including trust in institutions (Mazzoleni, 2008), all appear to shape both perceptions of corruption and the likelihood of tolerating it.

However, focusing on correlates of CT tells us more about the *who* and the *under which conditions*, and little about *why* people tolerate corruption. The persistence of CT, especially among those who condemn corruption morally, raises an explanatory puzzle. The next section turns to the main theoretical approaches that have been used to approach this issue and lays the groundwork for why social psychological perspectives such as SJT should be incorporated into our study of CT.

2.4 Explaining corruption tolerance

2.4.1 Rationalist explanations

Institutional and principal-agent approaches

Earlier accounts of CT largely rely on rational-choice and institutional frameworks. One prominent approach within this branch is to conceptualize corruption as a principal-agent problem, in which self-interested agents exploit information asymmetries and weak monitoring to pursue private gains (Groenendijk, 1997). Following this reasoning, the reason why corruption persists is that citizens lack the institutional tools needed to punish corrupt officials (Gouvêa Maciel, 2021, p. 1131). In practice, even in countries with proper democratic institutions in place corruption persists (Gouvêa Maciel, 2021 p. 1132), ultimately suggesting that institutional explanations alone are insufficient.

Collective action, coordination and information

Responding to this, a second branch of the literature reframed corruption as a collective action problem (Persson et al., 2013). From this perspective, even though individuals might condemn corruption, they won't act against it because they don't expect others to do it (Mungiu-Pippidi, 2013; Persson et al., 2013). Within this framework, information plays a crucial role. The idea is that if citizens are provided with the correct information, coordination problems can be overcome. Recent work by (Charron &

Bågenholm, 2025) applies this collective action logic to the “corruption voting paradox”, demonstrating that in Romanian municipal elections greater transparency about other voters’ intentions would have lowered abstention and increased the likelihood of removing corrupt incumbents.

Despite encouraging findings such as (Charron & Bågenholm, 2025)’s, the broader picture is bleak and suggests that information alone is insufficient. In writing about this specific issue, (Incerti, 2020, p. 761) notes that the literature showcases “little consensus on how voters respond to information about corrupt politicians”, meaning that providing credible information about corruption and how others are going to act does not consistently lead to the rejection of corrupt politicians. (Boas et al., 2019) show this clearly in Brazil: even when voters are informed about corruption, many still support corrupt politicians because they prioritize other considerations, such as loyalty to political dynasties. (Bauhr & Grimes, 2014) do not look at corruption voting specifically but also find that instead of triggering public indignation and collective action, transparency about widespread corruption can lead to resignation, challenging the idea according to which information alone reduces corruption.

These findings suggest that while information and coordination matter, they are filtered through social and psychological mechanisms that shape how corruption is interpreted.

2.4.2 Social explanations: identity and norms

Social norms

As hinted already, an increasingly influential social explanation focuses on norms, broadly defined as informal rules that guide our behavior (Köbis et al., 2018, p. 32). Social norms are commonly divided into injunctive norms, referring to “what one ought to do”, or, in other words, what is considered right and acceptable to do in a given context, and, descriptive norms, which have to do with “what one expects others to do”, therefore indicating how expected a behavior is based on its frequency (Köbis et al., 2018, p. 32).

(N. C. Köbis et al., 2015) provide experimental proof that descriptive norms in particular can impact corrupt behavior: individuals are more likely to tolerate corruption when they believe it is frequent and common, even if they personally disapprove of it (Köbis et al., 2018, p. 39).

Because descriptive norms are described as more malleable than injunctive norms (Köbis et al., 2015, p. 2), much anti-corruption messaging has focused on correcting beliefs about the prevalence of corruption. However, recent work by (Agerberg, 2022) challenges this narrow approach based solely on descriptive norms and shows that corrupt messaging correcting misperceptions of the prevailing injunctive norm also appears to be a promising avenue (Agerberg, 2022, p. 945).

While targeting norms seems a promising option to combat corruption, some considerations need to be made. First, responses to norm-based messaging vary substantially across individuals (Agerberg, 2022

p. 946), so success happens when they are targeted correctly ; moreover, as (Boas et al., 2019) show in the case of a Brazilian municipality, even in contexts characterized by strong anti-corruption norms, voters sometimes fail to punish corrupt incumbents when other considerations, such as group loyalties or the salience of other concerns are prioritized. This points to a key limitation of purely norm-based explanations and solutions: norms are interpreted through social and contextual lenses and can be trumped by other considerations.

Social identity theory

A growing literature argues that CT cannot be fully understood without considering social identity and group-based loyalties. Work in this strand of the literature is largely based on social identity theory (SIT) (Tajfel & Turner, 2004) and emphasizes the role that group identities have in shaping how individuals process information and morally evaluate behavior.

For example, (Solaz et al., 2019) provide evidence that voters are less likely to punish corrupt politicians that belong to their in-group. This happens both because in-group-bias makes it so that people tend to dismiss information about ingroup candidates being corrupt, and because people have an incentive to reward corruption of their in-group candidate as it is believed to increase the group's power and position (Solaz et al., 2019, p. 903).

A similar experimental study by (Cubel et al., 2024) also shows that people are more likely to support politicians of their same identity group. Unlike (Solaz et al., 2019) their paper emphasizes prior beliefs about honesty: voters tend to assume that same-identity politicians are inherently more trustworthy, which reduces the perceived severity of corruption. Importantly, this kind of logic goes beyond partisan identity, as in certain contexts loyalty is based on factors such as religion, ethnicity or language (Solaz et al., 2019, p. 901).

Undoubtably, SIT is well suited to explain selective tolerance driven by in-group favoritism. However, it is less equipped to account for tolerance shown by the out-group. This limitation has led scholars to adopt more integrative approaches that combine SIT with complementary theories.

2.4.3 Integrative cognitive-behavioral approaches

On a more general level, scholars increasingly seem to have realized the limitations of single-theory explanations, which has resulted in more “holistic” approaches.

A good example of this kind of approaches to the study of CT is (Pozsgai-Alvarez, 2022). The author argues that while most current policy interventions tend to rely on fragmented scientific evidence that examines single variables in isolation, the field would benefit from an approach that allows to understand how all these factors interact in creating the end outcome. In his study, CT is examined

looking at individual decision-making but controlling for political, economic and social factors that are known to be relevant, such as generalized trust, civic consciousness and economic welfare (Pozsgai-Alvarez, 2022, p. 385). Based on a wide survey fielded in Latin America, results indicate that engaging in corruption is closely related to the propensity toward moral disengagement as well as the centrality of an individual's moral identity. In order to do what it aims to do, (Pozsgai-Alvarez, 2022) builds its own cognitive model of corruption which draws from the basic structure of the Theory of Planned Behaviour (TPB) and integrates elements from ethical decision-making literature, namely moral development, moral disengagement, and the centrality of moral identity.

Similarly, (Takacs Haynes & Rašković, 2021 p. 826) claim that much is needed to be learned about the cognitive and behavioral mechanisms that stand behind unethical behavior, including corruption. Their paper draws on SIT (Tajfel & Turner, 1986) and Social Cognitive Theory (SCT) (Bandura, 1986) and focuses on exploring the role of moral disengagement (Newman et al., 2020). They propose what they call an “integrated social psychology framework”, which illustrates various kinds of moral disengagement mechanisms, different types of social embeddedness and social identity-based behavior in connection to corruption (Takacs Haynes and Rašković, 2021, p. 826). Interviews with experts reveal that in all the three countries subject to their study - Hungary, North Macedonia and Slovenia - people use a variety of moral disengagement mechanisms to live with unethical behavior (Takacs Haynes and Rašković, 2021, p. 838).

These approaches reinforce the idea that CT is not driven by a single factor but emerges from the interaction of norms, identities and cognitive processes. To end this section, the table below provides a summary of the main theoretical approaches used to explain CT that were discussed.

Table 2 Summarizing table of main approaches to CT

	THEORIES	HOW CORRUPTION TOLERANCE IS EXPLAINED	KEY MECHANISMS → SOLUTIONS	LIMITATIONS
Rationalist explanations Individuals tolerate corruption when it is costly or impossible to punish.	Principal-agent model	Citizens (principals) fail to sanction corrupt officials (agents)	Information asymmetries and weak monitoring → build institutional trust	Corruption persists even where institutional quality exists
	Collective action	Individuals oppose corruption but do not act because they expect others not to	Coordination failure and expectations → Provide information and align expectations	Studies show results vary when information is introduced
Social explanations Tolerance is socially constructed rather than purely strategic	Social norms theory (injunctive and descriptive norms)	People tolerate corruption based on what they believe is acceptable (injunctive norm) and/or common (descriptive norm)	Descriptive and injunctive norms as informal rules that guide our behavior → correct norms (ex. Norms messaging)	Norms are interpreted through social and contextual lenses and can be trumped by other considerations
	Social Identity Theory (SIT)	Corruption is “excused” or less perceived when committed by in-group members	In-group bias and identity based moral evaluations → Reframe corruption as harming the in-group, reduce identity cues	Limited explanatory power and fail to account for tolerance towards out-group corruption
Holistic approaches Corruption tolerance emerges from the interaction of cognitive, social and contextual factors	Mix of theoretical underpinnings (Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB), SIT, social norms theory, ...)	Corruption emerges from interacting social and cognitive processes.	Moral disengagement, identity bias, norms, contextual considerations → Multi-level interventions	Complex to test, but offers most comprehensive account of the phenomenon

3. Research gap and framework

This section sums up what has been presented up to this point and highlights the gaps this thesis aims to address. The overarching research puzzle and theory-informed sub-questions guiding the study are also presented here.

3.1 Framing the overarching puzzle

Corruption is often depicted as a problem that is very hard to eradicate because the very people that could bring about change are usually the ones who benefit from it the most (Rose, 2018, p. 220). While this is undeniable, this thesis shifts the analytical focus away from political elites and towards ordinary citizens.

In fact, as several scholars have noted, corruption persists not only because it benefits those in power, but also because it is tolerated, both actively and passively, by those who are harmed by it. Understanding this dynamic is crucial, because “[t]he fight against corruption can only be effective with the active and direct involvement of society, which is incompatible with permissiveness towards corruption.” (Alvarez-García et al., 2025, p. 22). What this ultimately means is that in order to fully tackle corruption, understanding the way people make sense of it and perceive it is essential (Transparency International, 2017 p.3).

Adding an additional layer of complexity is the puzzling finding that corrupt practices end up being tolerated in everyday life by people who claim to morally condemn it (Agerberg, 2022; Erlingsson & Kristinsson, 2018; Gouvêa Maciel, 2021; Pozsgai-Alvarez, 2022). This tension between moral condemnation and practical tolerance constitutes the core puzzle that motivates this thesis.

3.2 Literature synthesis: identifying gaps

The literature review allowed to show that academia has long recognized the importance of understanding CT. Scholars have approached the issue in different ways and have put forward a plethora of different explanations for the phenomenon, each offering important insights but also clear limitations.

Institutional and rational choice approaches focus on incentives and accountability but struggle to explain why corruption persists in democratic settings (Solaz et al., 2019). Collective action explanations highlight coordination problems, but studies show mixed results when information is introduced (Incerti, 2020). Approaches aimed at changing norms are promising (Köbis et al., 2018), but their effects are highly dependent on psychological mechanisms and end up being overridden by competing considerations (Boas et al., 2019). Social identity mechanism and ingroup biases are compelling explanations (Cubel et al., 2024), but on their own have limited explanatory power and fail to account for tolerance toward outgroup corruption. In response, scholars have recently tried to have

more holistic approaches that integrate social and cognitive mechanisms with political and economic factors (Pozsgai-Alvarez, 2022; Takacs Haynes & Rašković, 2021).

This evolution should be regarded as positive, as it signifies recognition of the complexity of the phenomenon and the inadequacy of single-theory explanations. Despite these advances, significant gaps remain in the study of CT. A recent systematic literature review by (Bravo et al., 2025) highlights two crucial aspects. First, there is a general messiness in what people measure when they talk about CT, with few papers precisely defining what they mean and the consequent tendency to measure different things, conflating attitudes, intention and actual behavior (Bravo et al., 2025, p. 4). In response to this, they propose their typology-based model, supposed to provide a “structured, theory-informed lens for diagnosing the field’s conceptual blind spots and guiding empirical research.” (Bravo et al., 2025, p. 15). Second, they remark that the field is still overwhelmingly painting tolerance as a moral stance instead of approaching it as a social and structural response, ultimately “underutilizing socio-cognitive constructs such as emotions, values, and personality traits” (Bravo et al., 2025, p. 14-15). An omission that is striking if one considers the huge influence emotions have on the way individuals’ reason and make choices (Bravo et al., 2025, p. 8).

Methodologically, research has also been uneven, with studies examining individual-level mechanisms remaining less common than studies looking at macro-level factors such as cultural or institutional factors (Takacs Haynes and Rašković, 2021, p. 825).

3.3 Research aims and questions

From a theoretical point of view, this study aims to fill the gap identified by (Bravo et al., 2025) by adopting System Justification Theory (SJT) as primary analytical framework. Under an SJT framework, in order to suppress and control negative emotional responses, individuals have a psychological motivation to maintain existing social and political arrangements that disadvantage them (Jost, 2019). To name just a few examples, the theory has been applied to explain why some women endorse gender inequality (Brescoll et al., 2013) or why racial minorities might justify discriminatory systems (Choma & Prusaczyk, 2018). Notably, Jost himself explicitly suggests applying SJT to understand CT (Jost, 2019, p. 286), yet SJT remains largely absent from the broader corruption literatures.

Importantly, the study does not treat SJT as a standalone explanation. In fact, SJT is there to complement other theoretical approaches, not replacing them (J. Jost, 2000). The argument is not that emotions are the single primary drivers of CT, but rather that they are likely to be an integral (so far underexplored) part of the motivational processes that underpin tolerant attitudes and behaviors towards corruption, and that, as such, they deserve attention.

From a methods perspective, this thesis opts for a cross-sectional mixed-methods online survey design combining quantitative measures with open-ended questions. As will be further discussed in the Methods section, this choice allows to examine the relationship between General System Justification (GSJ) and different dimensions of CT but also to explore emotional responses and potential system-justifying narratives that might not be captured through the GSJ scale alone.

Acknowledging the multidimensionality of CT, the overarching question guiding the study is: *how can the tension between moral condemnation of corruption and the persistence of corruption tolerance be understood?* The primary focus is on exploring whether system justification can be identified as a psychological mechanism that helps sustain CT, but alternative explanations are also considered.

To address this broader puzzle and in line with the aims of the study the thesis investigates a series of sub-questions:

- a) *To what extent does General System Justification (GSJ) predict different dimensions of corruption tolerance?*
- b) *How do citizens themselves understand and emotionally respond to corruption? Do system-justifying narratives emerge from their accounts?*
- c) *To what extent do alternative mechanisms (e.g., corruption perception, contextual factors, and social explanations) complement GSJ in explaining corruption tolerance?*

3.4 Contributions

Academically, this project strives to contribute both from a theoretical and a methodological standpoint.

From a methodological perspective, by relying on (Bravo et al., 2025)'s typology and capturing different manifestations of CT within the same sample, the thesis offers a small methodological contribution compared to studies that focus on only one dimension or that fail to specify what they are measuring altogether. Ultimately, the hope is also to contribute by adding to the already existing studies that manage to showcase the layered complexity of CT and the value of employing a multidimensional approach (Bravo et al., 2025, p. 13).

Theoretically, employing System Justification Theory (SJT) as primary analytical lens in the analysis of CT represents a somewhat underexplored approach that not only allows to further examine Jost's claim according to which SJT can illuminate tolerance for corruption, but also allows to address (Bravo et al., 2025)'s identified gap, thereby allowing for the acknowledgement of the emotional nature of CT that has so far been neglected. At the same time, stemming from the acknowledgement that CT is not a phenomenon likely to be explained by one single approach, this work strives to position itself among the most recent body of literature, adopting more holistic approaches that account for more than one

single explanation. Employing the typology developed by (Bravo et al., 2025) grounded in the Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB) ultimately allows “for the integration of macro situational processes that facilitate corruption with the micro psychological processes of individual decision-making to explain how corrupt behavior is motivated” (Bicchieri & Ganegoda, 2017, p. 181).

Constructing the thesis in this manner mainly served the purpose of exploring SJT as a potentially useful theory in addressing CT, and Italy was only chosen as a theoretically relevant context in which the mechanisms of interest could be explored. As such, the aim was not to produce a case study of the Italian context or to produce broadly generalizable findings.

That said, although not intended as a case study of Italy, the study may still provide some insights into which explanations appear particularly salient within the Italian context and therefore may still carry some practical implications. In particular, gaining a better understanding of the role emotions might play in tolerance of corruption may help inform the design of anti-corruption strategies that better account for the psychological costs of resistance.

4. Theoretical framework

After briefly introducing the origins and the core assumptions of SJT, the section turns to its application in the study of CT and ends by outlining exploratory expectations based on the theory and previous findings.

4.1 System Justification Theory: origins and core assumptions

A theory of system justification was first put forward by social and political psychologists John T. Jost and Mahzarin R. Banaji in 1994 to explain why individuals sometimes defend and legitimize social arrangements that appear to disadvantage them (J. T. Jost & Banaji, 1994, p. 2). While the theory builds on a wide span of sociological and philosophical thought (Jost, 2019, p. 264), a comprehensive discussion of its intellectual origins would greatly exceed the scope of this section. That said, a few words ought to be spent on its relationship with its two main predecessors: Social Identity Theory (SIT) (Tajfel & Turner, 1986) and Social Dominance Theory (SDT) (Sidanius & Pratto, 1993).

On paper, the three theories share a lot of common assumptions and are all concerned with group based processes and intergroup relations (J. Jost, 2000 p.48). However, Jost strongly argues for the need for SJT, claiming that it captures dynamics overlooked by its predecessors. In a nutshell, SJT adds to SIT by providing a proper account for the phenomenon of outgroup favoritism among the disadvantaged (Jost et al., 2004, p. 891), and, contrary to SDT, it does not take for granted and naturally given that the disadvantaged will be oppressed and do nothing about their oppression, but rather allows for the possibility of them to revolt (Jost et al., 2004, p. 887).

Critics have argued that cases of outgroup favoritism among disadvantaged groups *can* be explained by SIT, for example as patterns that simply reflect a passive acknowledgement of social reality or a form of in-group bias at the superordinate level (Owuamalam et al., 2018; J. T. Jost, 2019, p. 278). In response, (J. T. Jost, 2019) contends that these accounts underestimate the psychological significance of disadvantaged individuals endorsing an unequal status quo and miss the crucial distinction between group and system level justification. What appears as a simple acknowledgement of what “reality looks like” may hide a deeper motivational process aimed at reducing dissonance and preserving a sense of order and stability (Jost, 2019, p. 278). In this sense, SJT tries to capture a motivational dynamic that cannot fall under traditional group interest explanations.

Importantly, rather than replacing previous approaches, SJT should be understood as an extension. In Jost’s words, the theory functions as “a compliment, a complement, and in some ways also a corrective to its two predecessors” (J. Jost, 2000, p.5), drawing attention to the possibility that maintaining the status quo might itself satisfy important psychological needs.

Ultimately, taking outgroup favoritism seriously is about the acknowledgement that preserving the status quo is a collaborative process in which “everyone in his own way is both a victim and a supporter of the system” (Havel, 1978, p. 16; J. T. Jost et al., 2004, p. 909).

Core assumptions

One of the main characteristics of SJT is its emphasis on the system level. In fact, to *ego* justification (which refers to the need to maintain a positive image of oneself) and *group* justification (reflecting the desire to have favorable images of one’s group and defend fellow group members), SJT adds and put major emphasis on the third level of *system* justification, aimed at capturing social and psychological needs to consider the status quo as “good, fair, natural, desirable, and even inevitable” (Jost et al., 2004, p. 887).

Crucially, SJT posits that system-justifying tendencies can operate both at a conscious (active) and non-conscious level (passive) (J. T. Jost et al., 2004; Blasi & Jost, 2006, p. 1128), meaning that individuals might defend and rationalize the status quo without explicitly intending to do so.

A major tenet of the theory is its “palliative function”, referring to how engaging in SJ helps reduce negative emotions and psychological discomfort (Jost, 2019, p. 273). Concretely, SJ is theorized to lead to reduction of anxiety, guilt, dissonance, discomfort, and uncertainty (Jost and Hunyady, 2003, p. 111) and may a) help *prevent*, b) *manage*, or c) be a *reaction* to psychological strain (Jost and Hunyady, 2003, p. 147).

Jost and colleagues identify three motivational needs underlying SJ: (1) *epistemic motives*, tied to the desire for certainty, structure and control; (2) *existential motives*, referring to the desire for safety and security; and (3) *relational motives*, serving the idea of maintaining social harmony and a shared sense of reality (Jost et al., 2017, p. 101). As a matter of fact, challenging the status quo often requires people to face a great deal of psychological discomfort, including tolerating uncertainty, potential threats and risk of social alienation (Jost, 2019, p. 275), making SJ an attractive mechanism under some circumstances.

Notably, individuals differ in their propensity to engage in SJ (Kay & Friesen, 2011, p. 360; (Kesberg et al., 2024), with both *dispositional* and *situational* antecedents playing a role (J. T. Jost & Hunyady, 2005, p. 260). Traits such as need for certainty or perception of a dangerous world tend to be associated with stronger SJ (Jost and Hunyady, 2005, p. 261). Similarly, several situational factors such as a) high exposure to system criticism and perceiving that the system is in danger; b) feeling as though the system is inevitable or inescapable; c) the longer the “status quo” has been in place, and, lastly, d) feeling powerless and especially dependent on the system, have also been identified as “triggers” of SJ (Jost, 2019, p. 267).

An additional tenet of the theory is that endorsement of SJ ideologies can have both psychological and political consequences (Jost and Hunyady, 2005, p. 263). For the disadvantaged in particular, while SJ can provide short-term psychological benefits by reducing stress and increasing satisfaction, it may also carry long-term costs since rejecting more egalitarian alternatives has been associated with low self-esteem and depression in members of disadvantaged groups (Jost and Hunyady, 2005, p. 262). (Harding & Sibley, 2013) resolved this “theoretical inconsistency” by proposing a “time-course palliation hypothesis”, suggesting that there is a trade-off in how SJ offers gratification in the short term but ends up worsening the situation in the long term (Jost et al., 2019, p. 385). Lastly, perhaps the most significant consequence of SJ is that it has an impact on the support for system-challenging protest activity (Jost, 2019, p. 274). Indeed, since SJ is associated with lower levels of moral outrage it ends up affecting negatively the support for social change, both for advantaged and disadvantaged (Jost and Hunyady, 2005, p. 263).

4.2 Why System Justification Theory may matter for corruption tolerance

The central contribution of SJT lies in its attempt to understand the cases in which theories that are based on individual or collective forms of self-interest fall short of explaining individual’s behavior that seems counterintuitive. Applied to corruption, the theory raises the following question: why would ordinary citizens tolerate practices that ultimately disadvantage them?

The theory has been applied to a wide range of social problems (Jost, 2019, p. 285), including women endorsing gender inequality (Brescoll et al., 2013) racism (Choma & Prusaczyk, 2018), or climate change skepticism (Feygina et al., 2010) and Jost explicitly identifies corruption tolerance as an additional potentially relevant application of the theory (Jost, 2019, p. 286).

Based on the core assumptions of SJT, one would expect system-justifying tendencies to be associated with greater CT. The logic being that since SJ serves a palliative function by reducing uncertainty and psychological discomfort, tolerating corruption becomes a way to maintain stability and avoid the discomfort that would be associated with challenging the status quo. Following the theory, such mechanisms should be particularly present when corruption is perceived as deeply embedded in the system and as inescapable (Kay & Friesen, 2011, pp. 360–362; J. T. Jost, 2019, p. 267).

So far, only a limited number of studies have directly applied SJT to corruption, and their findings nuance the above expectation. In particular, (Tan et al., 2016) and (Tan et al., 2017) provide useful initial insight into the potential of this approach and reveal an important theoretical ambiguity.

While the former finds that General System Justification (GSJ) - a broad measure capturing the tendency to see the social, economic and political system as legitimate and fair - is negatively associated with

both corruption perception and intention, the latter finds that meritocratic ideology (a system justifying belief) is negatively associated with corruption perception, but positively associated with corruption intention (Tan et al., 2017, p. 469).

The two studies point to the fact that the relationship between system-justifying tendencies and corruption-related attitudes may not be straightforward. Depending on how SJ is operationalized, different patterns emerge. From a GSJ perspective, corruption seems to be more likely perceived as a threat and therefore challenged, on the contrary, from a meritocratic perspective, corruption is endorsed and minimized to keep the system working as it is (Tan et al., 2017, p. 471). Therefore, corruption can either be tolerated when perceived as an endogenous feature of how the system operates (Tan et al., 2017, p. 477) or be rejected if perceived as a threat to system stability (Jost, 2019) (Tan et al., 2017, p. 470).

Expectations

Drawing on SJT, this study conducts an exploratory quantitative investigation of the relationship between GSJ and CT in Italy.

Based on the theory, the main expectation is that stronger GSJ might be positively associated with CT, because tolerance may become a way to cope with how the system works and reduce discomfort associated with challenging the status quo.

However, previous findings by (Tan et al., 2016) and (Tan et al., 2017) suggest that GSJ could engender a competing mechanism: push people to reject corruption as a threat to system stability, and therefore reduce tolerance (J. T. Jost, 2019; Tan et al., 2017, p. 470).

At the same time, it is also possible that GSJ may display only weak or null relationships with CT. This may indicate two possible things: either that other factors are more salient and that the sample under scrutiny is not particularly likely to engage in SJ, or, that GSJ scale may not fully capture SJ mechanisms. As hinted already, SJT recognizes that SJ can operate both at a conscious (active) and non-conscious (passive) level (J. T. Jost et al., 2004) and reveal itself on “open-ended, nonreactive, qualitative measures and on implicit (as well as explicit) cognitive, affective, and behavioral measures” (Jost and Hunyady, 2003, p. 148) (Jost et al., 2004, p. 893). For this reason, the study combines quantitative analysis with qualitative open-ended questions aimed at identifying potential SJ narratives.

Lastly, given the multidimensional nature of CT, effects of GSJ are expected to potentially vary across its different dimensions. Since there is limited previous research regarding how such variation may emerge, no specific expectations in this regard are formulated.

5. Methods

This thesis adopts a mixed methods survey design, integrating quantitative and qualitative items in the same instrument. Data were collected through a cross-sectional self-administered web survey, via the online survey platform Qualtrics. This section first outlines the overall research design and rationale behind the design choices, before discussing data collection, operationalization for the main concepts and analytical strategy.

5.1 Mixed methods research design

The core component of a mixed methods design involves the collection and analysis of both qualitative and quantitative data to answer research questions (Creswell, 2014, p. 266). Within survey research, mixed methods designs can differ depending on the role assigned to the qualitative component and whether qualitative and quantitative phases occur sequentially or concurrently (Mauceri, 2016, p. 1218).

In this study, qualitative and quantitative data were collected concurrently, and the qualitative component mainly served a complementary role while also contributing to the integration and interpretation of quantitative findings. The design does not perfectly fit in any of the standardized “recipes”, proposed by methods manuals. Rather, it follows the advice according to which research designs should be built around “the best possible combination of qualitative and quantitative techniques based on the goals of the inquiry” (Mauceri, 2016, p. 1228-1229).

The main goal of this thesis was to explore whether SJ mechanisms may shape CT, while remaining considerate of other explanations identified in previous literature. A mixed method survey represented the best approach for several reasons. On the one hand, the quantitative component allowed for the collection of enough responses to conduct meaningful analysis and was particularly suitable given both the sensitive nature of the topic and the feasibility constraints of the study. On the other hand, the inclusion of a qualitative component was deemed necessary to better explore the emotional and affective side of CT, as well as to identify potential SJ narratives that might not be fully captured by the GSJ scale. Ultimately, integrating the two different types of data was intended to get insights beyond what either component could have provided on its own (Creswell and Hirose, 2019, p. 2).

5.2 Case selection

For reasons of analytical focus and feasibility, the study was fielded in Italy. To capture the paradox at the heart of the overarching research question, participants were to be selected from a context that met three criteria: 1) presence of a strong injunctive norm against corruption, 2) continued prevalence of corruption in practice, and 3) high levels of perceived corruption among citizens. Together, these conditions capture the tension between formal moral condemnation and persistence of corruption in

practice, while also increasing the likelihood that citizens are exposed to corruption as a salient social issue.

Italy broadly fulfils all three criteria and therefore represents a theoretically relevant context. Survey data from a special Eurobarometer survey conducted in 2025 on Citizens' attitudes towards corruption in the EU indicate that 1) most Italians consider corruption unacceptable (EU Commission, 2025, pp. 14–17), suggesting a strong injunctive norm against corruption, despite this, 2) Italy ranks 52/180 on Transparency International Corruption Perception Index (*Italy*, 2025), placing below most Western European countries. Lastly, 3) 85% of Italians think corruption is “widespread” in their country (National Factsheet - Italy, 2025).

In sum, the coexistence of a strong injunctive norm against corruption, perceived prevalence and somewhat objective presence of the issue made Italy a suitable context for exploring how citizens reconcile anti-corruption values with varying forms of CT.

5.3 Survey design

The study employed a cross-sectional, self-administered online survey design (Callegaro et al., 2015, p. 6-22). This approach was selected because of the many advantages that it offers, including reduced cost, geographic flexibility, reduced risk of social desirability bias, and its suitability when it comes to the study of sensitive topics like corruption (Callegaro et al., 2015, p. 33). At the same time, online surveys present important limitations, including self-selection bias (which may produce uneven representation), reduced control over the conditions under which responses are completed, as well as accessibility problems for people who are not very technically savvy, such as older people (Callegaro et al., 2015, p. 33 -35). Despite the limitations, the method remains appropriate for the present study, particularly due to its efficiency, accessibility and suitability for sensitive topics.

Designing a survey broadly implies three main steps: 1) designing questions 2) sampling and 3) data collection (Fowler, 2009, p. 9). The remaining of this section briefly reviews these stages, starting with the design of the questionnaire and the operationalization of key concepts, followed by sampling procedures, and, finally, the data collection process.

5.3.1 Designing the questionnaire

The questionnaire was built on the theoretical framework and literature review, with the aim of operationalizing key concepts of the study. In particular, it was designed to explore the relationship between GSJ and CT in all its dimensions. While the thesis focuses primarily on the role of SJ, the survey was designed in a way that also allowed for the examination of alternative explanations discussed in the literature. Furthermore, given that “[s]ystem justification occurs even on open-ended, nonreactive, qualitative measures and on implicit (as well as explicit) cognitive, affective, and behavioral measures”

(Jost and Hunyady, 2003, p. 148), direct measures were combined with indirect open-ended questions intended to capture narratives and emotional responses.

Questionnaire structure

The survey was first redacted in English and then translated in Italian. The English version can be found in Appendix A.

The final version of the survey consisted of nine blocks, counting an introductory and conclusive block. When clicking on the survey link, respondents were first introduced to the topic of the study, including its purpose, estimated duration, participation requirements and guarantee of anonymity. They were then asked to confirm that they were above 18 years old, held Italian citizenship and resided in Italy. To ease respondents into the survey, the instrument started with three simple socio-demographic questions, namely age, gender and region. The rest of the socio-demographic questions, including income, political orientation and education level, were added at the end to reduce respondents' fatigue and potential discouragement. The initial section was followed by the measurement of the main independent variable, GSJ, using an adapted version of the General System Justification scale. The ensuing sections addressed corruption-related attitudes, including perception, exposure and tolerance. Additional sections addressed political attitudes and behavioral intentions, such as willingness to report or protest against corruption. Two open-ended questions were included to capture respondents reasoning and emotional responses to corruption, and a vignette-based question was used to assess decision making processes and alternative explanations.

Table 3 Overview of questionnaire structure

Blocks	Content
1	General consent + consent + eligibility
2	Basic demographics (gender, age, region)
3	General System Justification (GSJ) Scale
4	Corruption items: corruption perception, corruption exposure and five dimensions of corruption tolerance
5	Anti-corruption attitudes (likelihood to engage in challenging activity)
6	Open-ended questions on corruption persistence and emotional reactions
7	Vignette-based question examining alternative explanations
8	Extended socio-demographic variables (education, income, religion, political orientation)
9	Closing section

Key variables and operationalization

General System Justification (GSJ)

In order to operationalize SJ, this study employed the General System Justification Scale and its eight items as first developed by (Kay & Jost, 2003) and subsequently used by other authors such as (Vesper et al., 2022). The scale was adapted to Italy and translated in Italian. Respondents were asked to respond how much they agreed or disagreed with the eight statements, using a 1-7 Likert scale. After reverse-coding negatively worded items responses were averaged into a single GSJ index, where higher values indicated stronger GSJ tendencies. The scale demonstrated acceptable internal consistency (Cronbach's $\alpha = .77$). Full item wording is reported in Appendix A.

Corruption perception

A separate measure of CP was created from the item assessing perceived prevalence of corruption (*How widespread do you think corruption is in Italy?*). Responses were recorded on a five point-scale ranging from *very widespread* to *very rare*. Responses were recoded so that higher values indicate stronger perception that corruption is widespread, while “don't know” values were treated as missing values.

Corruption tolerance

Corruption tolerance, the main dependent variable, was operationalized following (Bravo et al., 2025)'s typology. For all dimensions except one (normative tolerance), matrix tables were used to differentiate between four public-service types, namely: 1) *Healthcare services* (e.g., access to medical consultations or treatments in public hospitals; diagnostic tests); 2) *Permits and administrative procedures* (e.g., building permits; business licenses; other bureaucratic authorizations); 3) *Educational services* (e.g., exam registration; enrolment; grade management); and, lastly, 4) *Official documents and certifications* (e.g., vehicle registration; issuance of identity documents; various certificates).

Questions in this block were randomized to minimize order effects and reduce priming bias, thereby improving the reliability of responses.

Table 4 Operationalization of CT

CT dimensions	Survey item
Normative CT: “focuses on the perceived social or moral acceptability of corrupt acts within a given context.” (Bravo et al., 2025, p. 14).	<i>In your opinion, for most Italians, how acceptable is corruption?</i>
Intentional CT: “captures individuals’ self-declared willingness to engage in corruption under hypothetical or conditional scenarios” (Bravo et al., 2025, p. 14)	<i>Imagine that you need one of the following public services and someone suggests that a small unofficial payment could speed up or facilitate the process. In each case, how likely would you be to make such informal payment?</i>
Attitudinal CT: “captures evaluative judgments about whether corruption is justifiable or acceptable” (Bravo et al., 2025, p. 14)	<i>In your opinion, how justifiable is it for a public official to accept a gift or money in exchange for providing or speeding up the following public services?</i>
Practical CT: “captures judgments shaped by feasibility, risk, or contextual constraints - such as the likelihood of being caught.” (Bravo et al., 2025, p. 14)	<i>In some situations, people may feel that resorting to informal payments or favors is the only way to obtain an important public service. In such cases, how acceptable do you consider this behavior?</i>
Behavioral CT: “reflects individuals’ enacted tolerance, operationalized through self-reported past behaviors or simulated decisions in experimental designs.” (Bravo et al., 2025, p. 14)	<i>Sometimes people are encouraged to make a small unofficial extra payment to speed up or facilitate a public service. If this were to happen in the following situations, what would you be most likely to do?</i>

Normative tolerance was measured by using a single survey item asking how acceptable corruption is perceived to be. “Don’t know” responses were coded as missing.

Attitudinal, intentional and practical tolerance were each operationalized as indices based on the mean of the four scenario-based items. Internal consistency was satisfactory across all scales, with Cronbach’s α values ranging from 0.86 to 0.89 (see Appendix D, Table D2).

Behavioral tolerance, by contrast, was transformed into a binary indicator, where respondents willing to engage in a corrupt act were coded as 1, and those preferring refusal or finding alternatives were coded as 0. While four scenarios were initially created, only Scenario 1 was retained for the main regression analyses. The reason for this was that the remaining behavioral scenarios displayed extremely limited variation, with willingness to engage remaining below 4% across contexts. Scenario 1 therefore provided the clearest behavioral differentiation within the sample. The remaining behavioral indicators were retained for descriptive comparisons of contextual differences. Further details regarding the operationalization choices relating to behavioral tolerance can be found in Appendix C.

Open-ended questions

Two open-ended questions were included to capture respondents reasoning and emotional responses to corruption.

1.	In your opinion, what are the reasons why corruption persists in Italy?
2.	How do you feel when you hear about a corruption scandal or are personally confronted with acts of corruption?

Accounting for alternative explanations

Respondents were asked to imagine a situation in which they would vote for what they know to be a corrupt incumbent and indicate the reasons that would justify such a choice. Response options were theory informed and designed to capture both SJT and other alternative theoretical frameworks, including rational choice/performance-based reasoning, social identity theory, collective action logic, and moral disengagement/pragmatism. An “other (please specify)” option was included to allow respondents to indicate reasons not captured by the predefined categories.

Table 5 Response options and corresponding theoretical frameworks

Response options	Theoretical grounding
Option 1: The politician in question has delivered good results, and for me, this is more important than the corruption allegations.	Rational choice (performance voting)
Option 2: Replacing the politician could put at risk the provision of essential services I rely on, so I might prefer continuity despite the corruption.	System Justification Theory (dependency on the system)
Option 3: I do not expect other voters to withdraw their support for this reason, so my own behaviour would not have any impact.	Collective action logic
Option 4: The politician belongs to a party or group that represents my interests.	Social Identity Theory (group interest)
Option 5: Even if corruption exists, maintaining a stable political system is more important to ensure reliable services and the normal functioning of daily life.	System Justification Theory (need for stability)
Option 6: Corruption may be wrong, but sometimes it is necessary to make things work.	Moral disengagement
Option 7: Many people criticize the system, but I feel that supporting it is the safest way to avoid chaos or negative consequences.	System Justification Theory (need for certainty and security)
Option 8: Other (specify)	

5.3.2 Sampling and data collection

Since studying entire populations is usually quite complicated, researchers rely on representative samples that allow for inferences about the wider population (Creswell and Hirose, 2019, p. 3). Good sampling happens when all members of the population of interest have the exact same chance of being picked to answer the survey, and this most likely happens by relying on probability methods (Fowler, 2009, p. 16). Due to time and resource constraints typical of a master thesis, this study had to rely on a non-probability sample approach. More specifically, a combination of convenience and snowball sampling was used, which resulted in a sample with very little actual representative power. Data were collected via a self-administered online survey hosted on Qualtrics, a popular online survey tool (Creswell and Hirose, 2019, p. 3). Prior to distribution, the survey was pretested to identify potential issues related to clarity and completion time (Fowler, 2009, p. 17).

Implications tied to the low representativeness of the sample are addressed in the later Limitations section, whereas additional details regarding the sampling and data collection are provided in Appendix B.

5.4 Data analysis strategy

The analysis strategy was initially divided into two parts. Quantitative analysis first examined the relationship between GSJ and CT, alongside additional GSJ-related and supplementary analyses. This was followed by the qualitative analysis of the two open-ended questions, which aimed at gaining insights into respondents reasonings and emotional responses to corruption. The qualitative analysis occasionally informed further quantitative inquiries, thereby creating an iterative rather than strictly linear approach to the study. At a later stage, findings from both components were integrated with each other and jointly informed the Discussion. The main aspects guiding analysis for each component are elaborated on in the next section.

5.4.1 Quantitative analysis

The quantitative analysis was conducted using Stata with a mix of descriptive and inferential techniques. Prior to analysis, the dataset was cleaned and prepared. Incomplete responses were kept where possible, which resulted in variation of usable observations across variables and models. Details regarding the operationalization and construction of variables can be found in Appendix D. The analysis was structured into three parts: 1) Descriptives, 2) a set of main analyses directly addressing the central research question and GSJ related relationships, and 3) a set of supplementary analyses exploring additional explanatory factors and the importance of context.

1) *Descriptive statistics*

Descriptive statistics were used to provide an overview of the sample and the main variable of interest.

2) *Main analyses*

The main analyses focused on examining whether and how GSJ was associated with different dimensions of CT. To do that, five multivariate models were estimated using different dimensions of CT as DVs. OLS regression was used for attitudinal, intentional, practical, and normative tolerance measures, while logistic regression was used for the binary behavioral measure. All models controlled for age, gender, education and ideology. To enhance interpretation, adjusted predicted values and marginal effects were estimated for statistically significant models.

To further explore the multidimensional nature of CT and potential discrepancies between moral attitudes and behavioral intentions, a further analysis examined the norm-practice paradox. A variable capturing the norm-practice paradox was constructed identifying respondents who both strongly condemned corruption and reported willingness to engage in it. A binary variable for *moral condemnation* was created based on attitudinal tolerance (Q13), where respondents who strongly condemned corruption were coded as 1, and all others as 0. Behavioral willingness was measured using

the binary corruption behavior variable (1 = pay ; 0 = refuse/alternative). Importantly, the analysis was restricted to respondents with valid responses on both variables, resulting in a reduced sample (N = 224). A *paradox* indicator was then defined as respondents who both strongly condemned corruption and reported willingness to engage in it. It was then examined whether GSJ predicted the likelihood of exhibiting the paradox. For this, logistic regression models were estimated, as well as additional models including socio-demographic controls.

Finally, two additional exploratory analyses related to GSJ were carried out. First, socio-demographic correlates of GSJ using descriptive subgroup means and OLS regression models were examined. This allowed assessment of which categories of respondents tended to display higher levels of GSJ within the sample. Second, regression models controlling age, gender, education, and political orientation were estimated to assess whether GSJ predicted willingness to engage in anti-corruption activity, operationalized as self-reported likelihood of either reporting corruption or participating in a protest.

3) Supplementary analysis

A second set of analyses explored the relationship between CP and CT, salience of additional explanatory mechanisms and the relative importance of context when it comes to corruption tolerance.

Associations between CP and the different dimensions of CT were explored. Once again, OLS regression models were estimated for all dimensions except behavioral tolerance, which was instead approached using logistic regression. All models included age, gender, education and ideology as controls. To assess substantive significance, predicted values were estimated for respondents one standard deviation below and above the sample mean on the measure of CP.

Next, differences in CT across contextual service scenarios were examined using comparison of mean values, allowing to investigate whether tolerance varied depending on situational factors such as perceived necessity.

Lastly, the vignette-based item was analyzed descriptively to assess relative salience of different justificatory narratives used to explain potential support for corrupt incumbents. Frequencies were calculated for each response category.

5.4.2 Qualitative analyses

The open-ended responses were analyzed through a two-stage qualitative strategy combining content analysis (CA) and reflexive thematic analysis (TA). Broadly speaking, the analysis ended up following (Braun & Clarke, 2006)'s six steps framework, progressing from familiarization and coding (in this case corresponding with the CA phase) to theme development and interpretation.

The preliminary CA was first conducted to identify and quantify recurring terms and patterns in the responses (Elo & Kyngäs, 2008, p. 108). More specifically, a preliminary word frequency query was conducted in Nvivo. A minimum word length of 5 characters was applied to exclude common short function words, and a stop words list was developed to remove prominent but analytically insignificant terms. The purpose of this phase was primarily exploratory and descriptive, helping to familiarize with the data while identifying recurring concepts that ended up informing the coding process.

Initial coding focused on recurring explanations for corruption persistence, emotional responses to corruption, references to institutional inefficacy, normalization and narratives of resignation and necessity. Codes were iteratively refined and grouped into broader thematic categories. The coding tables that informed the analysis can be found in Appendix F.

Following initial coding, reflexive TA was employed to interpret broader patterns of meaning and move beyond coding by developing themes that capture both explicit (semantic) and underlying (latent) meanings (Clarke & Braun, 2017, pp. 297–298).

Although the study puts major emphasis on SJT, a primarily inductive approach was used. Given the exploratory nature of the study and its aim to understand how respondents themselves narrate and make sense of corruption, using a predefined deductive coding framework based on SJT carried the risk of missing other important mechanisms. Therefore, SJT ended up functioning as interpretative lens rather than as a strict coding template. This approach, anchored in the theoretical flexibility that characterizes TA (Braun and Clarke, 2006, p. 78), allowed to remain open to alternative explanatory mechanisms emerging from respondents' narratives.

Ultimately, the combined approach allowed for both descriptive and more quantifiable insights while also providing some room for interpretations of deeper latent meanings (Vaismoradi et al., 2013, p. 400), thereby enhancing the overall analytical depth of the study.

5.5 Limitations

There are several methodological limitations that should be acknowledged when interpreting the findings of this study.

First, the sample was not representative of the Italian population. Participation was based on voluntary survey responses and non-probability sampling methods were used, which likely introduced self-selection bias (Callegaro et al., 2015, p. 33-35). The sample was particularly skewed in terms of geographic representation, as well as political orientation, which obviously affected the extent to which findings could be generalized. Second, the sample size was relatively modest. While enough for exploratory analyses, some subgroup categories contained only very small number of observations. Statistical power was therefore negatively affected. Third, since a cross-sectional design was used, the

study relied on data collected at a single point in time (Callegaro et al., 2015, p. 6). As a result, the analysis only identified association rather than casual relationships. Lastly, the sensitive topic under study makes it impossible to rule out potential social desirability bias (Breitenstein et al., 2022, p. 2). That said, this risk was hopefully partly mitigated by encouraging participants to respond as honestly as possible and by guaranteeing full anonymity.

Despite these limitations, which require findings to be interpreted as exploratory rather than definitive, useful information on the varied mechanisms that shape CT arose from the analysis, pointing to potential future avenues of research using larger and more presentative samples.

6. Results

6.1 Descriptive statistics

6.1.1 Sample description

The original dataset contained 360 observations and 75 variables. Although the number of registered responses was 360, it is important to note that the number of valid responses varied across questions. For example, age, gender and region each had 311 valid responses, while education and political ideology (which were placed at the end of the survey) only gathered a total of 235 responses.

Generally, it was a relatively young sample. The most represented age group was 18-24 (37.62%), followed by 25-35 (18.33%) and 56-65 (16.08%). Together, respondents under 35 made up nearly 56% of the whole sample and people 65+ represented only about 11% of the whole population.

The sample was also quite skewed when it comes to regional representation. Lombardy was by far the most represented region (36.5%), followed by Emilia-Romagna (10.3%) and Veneto (10%). The result was that the sample was heavily concentrated in Northern Italy (71%), with a much smaller share of respondents from the South and the Islands (19%) and the Centre (10%).

When it comes to gender, the sample was a bit more balanced, with female respondents accounting for 55.3% of the sample and males 44.05%. Only two individuals chose the “prefer not to disclose” option.

Educational level was relatively high, with most respondents holding at least a secondary school diploma (40%), and a substantial portion having completed a university education, including both bachelor’s (21.3%) and master’s degree (24.3%).

Lastly, the sample was skewed towards progressive views, with the majority identifying as either somewhat (34.9%) or strongly (24.3%) progressive. Moderate respondents accounted for 22.6%, while conservative positions were only marginally represented.

6.1.2 Main variables

The average level of GSJ, the main independent variable, was 2.92 (SD = 0.87). This was well below the midpoint, indicating a moderate level of support for the existing social system within the sample.

Turning to the main independent variables, the sample displayed low tolerance across almost all dimensions. Attitudinal tolerance was the lowest ($M = 1.24$, $SD = 0.55$), indicating strong moral rejection of corruption. Practical ($M = 1.62$, $SD = 0.82$) and intentional tolerance ($M = 1.97$, $SD = 0.96$) were slightly higher, perhaps suggesting that respondents are more willing to accept or engage in corruption under certain conditions than their moral evaluations alone would imply. Normative tolerance (operationalized as “How acceptable do you think corruption is in Italy?”) was much higher

($M = 2.92$, $SD = 0.97$), indicating that respondents perceived corruption as more socially accepted by others.

For the behavioral dimension (measured as a binary indicator of engagement in corruption-related actions) 13.4% of respondents reported being willing to make the informal payment, while the majority (86.6%) indicated no willingness.

Finally, corruption perception was rather high ($M = 4.06$, $SD = 0.79$), suggesting that respondents perceived corruption as common and widespread in the context of Italy.

6.2 System justification and corruption tolerance

6.2.1 General System Justification and corruption tolerance

Table 6 presents the controlled regression models examining the relationship between GSJ and the different dimensions of CT. Overall, GSJ did not have a uniform effect across the five outcomes measures. As shown in Model 4, the only statistically significant relationships emerged between GSJ and normative tolerance.

Table 6 Effect of GSJ on Corruption Tolerance

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	Attitudinal	Intentional	Practical	Normative	Behavioral (logit)
General System Justification (GSJ)	0.076 (0.042)	-0.082 (0.075)	-0.030 (0.064)	-0.290** (0.088)	-0.318 (0.296)
Observations	235	235	235	225	176
R-squared	0.104	0.234	0.174	0.190	-
Pseudo R-squared	-	-	-	-	0.104

Note: Robust standard errors in parentheses. All models control for age, gender, education, and political orientation. Models 1–4 estimated using OLS regression; Model 5 estimated using logistic regression. Reference categories: Age = 18–24; Gender = Male; Education = Lower secondary education; Political orientation = Very progressive/liberal. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

More specifically, Model 1 showed a positive but statistically insignificant relationship, suggesting a weak tendency for individual high in GSJ to express slightly more moral acceptance of corruption. Models 2 and 3 both revealed a negative yet statistically insignificant relationship between GSJ and intentional and practical tolerance. Similarly, Model 5 (estimated using logistic regression) also indicated a negative but not statistically significant association between GSJ and corrupt behavior.

The only robust finding concerned normative corruption tolerance. As shown in Model 4, a strong and statistically significant negative association was observed, suggesting that GSJ was negatively associated with perceptions that corruption is socially tolerated by others. To assess substantive significance, predicted values were estimated for respondents scoring one standard deviation ($SD = 0.87$) below and above the mean of GSJ ($M = 2.92$). Holding controls constant, individuals low in GSJ ($GSJ = 2.05$) were predicted to score 3.19 on normative corruption tolerance, compared with 2.68 among

high GSJ respondents (GSJ =3.79). This represented a 0.51-point decrease on the five-point scale, indicating a moderate substantive effect.

By controlling for sociodemographic characteristics, gender, education and political orientation showed inconsistent and limited effects across models. On the contrary, age came out as a consistent predictor, with older respondents showcasing lower level of tolerance, especially on the intentional and practical dimensions. Respondents aged 18-24 had a predicted score of 2.25, whereas those aged 56-65 scored 1.46, indicating a decline of representing a decrease of approximately 0.79 scale points. A very similar pattern emerged for practical tolerance, where predicted values from margins analysis showed a clear downward trend: tolerance declined with age, from a predicted score of 1.92 among 18-24-year-olds to 1.26 among respondents aged 56-65, suggesting younger respondents were more accepting of corruption in practical situations. For full regression outputs including all control variables, see Appendix E, Table E1.

6.2.2 The norm-practice paradox

The analysis revealed some evidence of the norm-practice paradox, although it remained limited in the sample. Within the analytical sample (N = 224), 92.4% of respondents strongly condemned corruption, whereas only 7.6% did not. Among those who strongly condemned corruption, 11.6% still reported willingness to engage in corrupt behavior. On the contrary, among respondents who did not strongly condemn corruption (7.6%), a higher proportion (35.3%) reported willingness to engage in corruption, suggesting that moral attitudes remain an important predictor of behavior.

Table 7 shows that results indicated a negative but non-significant association between GSJ and the likelihood of displaying the paradox. The direction of the relationship suggests that respondents with higher GSJ scores were somewhat less likely to display inconsistencies between moral condemnation and behavior. However, the relationship remained weak and should therefore be interpreted cautiously.

Table 7 Effect of GSJ on the Norm-Practice Paradox

	(1) Bivariate model	(2) Controlled model
General System Justification (GSJ)	-0.336 (0.272)	-0.331 (0.323)
Observations	207	171
Pseudo R-squared	0.011	0.094

Notes: Robust standard errors in parentheses. Model 2 controls for age, gender, and political orientation. Both models estimated using logistic regression.
* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

When controlling socio-demographic variables (Model 2), GSJ remained negatively associated and statistically insignificant. While gender and political orientation did not show significant effects, age emerged as a significant predictor: as age increased, individuals were less likely to showcase the

paradox. In particular, respondents aged 56–65 were significantly less likely than the youngest age group (18-24) to display inconsistencies between moral condemnation and behavioral willingness. Full regression outputs including all control variables are reported in Appendix E Table E2.

6.2.3 Additional exploratory GSJ-related analyses

Who scores higher on the GSJ scale?

Descriptively, looking at means revealed that GSJ seemed to increase with age, however not in a linear way. Men showed higher GSJ than women, and when it comes to education, many categories had very small N so no claims were possible.

Political orientation showed the clearest descriptive pattern. Ignoring the very conservative category, which only had two respondents, GSJ increased linearly: people scored higher as you moved towards the centre and the right of the political spectrum. In the regression analysis, the original political orientation variable was recoded into to a binary variable because of the small number of respondents in the conservative categories, so the model only distinguished between progressive and moderate respondents. The results confirmed that progressives showcased lower levels of GSJ compared to moderates, however the coefficient was not significant (see Appendix E Table E4).

A subsequent exploratory inspection of the top five higher and lower GSJ scores revealed that some high-GSJ individuals also reported relatively higher household income levels. This motivated a full sample test of the relationship between income and GSJ. Descriptively, the mean GSJ increased across household income categories, from 2.48 among respondents earning less than €1,000 monthly to 3.17 among those reporting €7,000 or more. However, regression analyses revealed that the relationship was not statistically significant. This exploration revealed that income may be positively associated with GSJ, but as for this sample, the evidence remains suggestive rather than conclusive. The modest sample size and the many categories are possible reasons why it is not statistically significant.

GSJ and anti-corruption action

Regression analysis revealed no statistically significant association between GSJ and willingness to report corruption. Contrary to theoretical expectations, individuals higher in GSJ were not less likely to express support for anti-corruption activity. Looking at control variables, politically progressive respondents reported slightly higher willingness to denounce corruption than moderates, although this effect was modest. More interestingly, some age categories showed higher willingness to report than the youngest reference group, such as respondents aged 56–65 (see Appendix E Table E5).

6.3 Beyond system justification: complementary mechanisms relating to corruption tolerance

6.3.1 Corruption perception and corruption tolerance

As Table 8 shows, regression including controls revealed that only the effect on normative tolerance was significant (Model 4).

Table 8 Effect of Corruption Perception on Corruption Tolerance

	(1) Attitudinal	(2) Intentional	(3) Practical	(4) Normative	(5) Behavioural (logit)
Corruption perception	-0.079 (0.065)	0.050 (0.087)	-0.008 (0.075)	0.366*** (0.088)	-0.228 (0.269)
Observations	232	232	232	224	174
R-squared	0.103	0.238	0.169	0.218	-
Pseudo R-squared	-	-	-	-	0.098

Notes: Robust standard errors in parentheses. All models control for age, gender, education, and political orientation. Models 1-4 estimated with OLS regression; Model 5 estimated with logistic regression.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

To assess substantive significance, predicted values were estimated for respondents one standard deviation below and above the sample mean on the measure of CP. Given a sample mean of 4.06 and a standard deviation of 0.80, this corresponded to values of 3.26 and 4.87. Holding all control variables constant, respondents one standard deviation below the mean were predicted to score 2.66 on normative corruption tolerance, compared with 3.25 among respondents one standard deviation above the mean. This represented a 0.59-point increase on the five-point scale, indicating a moderate substantive effect. Ultimately, CP mainly influenced individuals' perception of social norms related to corruption, rather than their moral attitudes, intentions or behavior. Full regression models are reported in Appendix E Table E3.

6.3.2 Contextual differences

Results indicated that corruption tolerance did vary across contexts. In the intentional dimension, respondents reported the highest willingness to engage in corruption in Scenario 1 ($M = 2.52$) and the lowest in Scenario 3 ($M = 1.70$). A similar pattern was observed in the practical dimension, where Scenario 1 again showed the highest tolerance ($M = 1.94$), while Scenario 2 displayed the lowest levels ($M = 1.49$). The behavioral measure further reinforced the importance of context: the proportion of respondents willing to engage in corruption was substantially higher in Scenario 1 (13.4%), compared to all other scenarios, where it remained below 4%. By contrast, attitudinal tolerance remained consistently low across scenarios (ranging from $M = 1.18$ to $M = 1.34$), suggesting that moral condemnation of corruption was relatively stable and less sensitive to contextual variation. Overall, Scenario 1 consistently recorded the higher tolerance. Results are reported in Appendix D, Table D4.

6.3.3 Alternative explanations

Out of the eight possible options, the most selected was Option 8, where people were asked to specify other reasons as to why they would support a corrupt incumbent. Among the 84 respondents who chose this option, a large share explicitly rejected the possibility of supporting a corrupt politician under any circumstance, using statements such as “no reason,” “I would no longer support them”.

Out of the more concrete options, Option 1 was the most selected (22.4%), suggesting that performance voting and more rational evaluation types of explanations were quite salient within the sample. The second strongest was Option 4 (20.6%), indicating the importance of group interest. Option 2 (18.4%), which is tied to system dependency and continuity concerns, was the third most selected. After this, mid-level support for options 5 (11.4%) and options 7 (10.5%) emerged, which are the other two SJT-inspired options, one tied to system stability and the other to the avoidance of chaos. Together, these three accounted for the salience of SJT. The least selected options were Option 6 (7.9%), suggesting that direct normalization of corruption was quite unpopular in the sample, and Option 3 (5.7%).

Table 9 Distribution of vignette response options

Response option	Theory	N	%
Option 8: Other (specify)	Open response	84	36.8%
Option 1: The politician in question has delivered good results, and for me, this is more important than the corruption allegations.	Rational choice (performance voting)	51	22.4%
Option 4: The politician belongs to a party or group that represents my interests.	Social Identity Theory (group interest)	47	20.6%
Option 2: Replacing the politician could put at risk the provision of essential services I rely on, so I might prefer continuity despite the corruption.	System Justification Theory	42	18.4%
Option 5: Even if corruption exists, maintaining a stable political system is more important to ensure reliable services and the normal functioning of daily life.	System Justification Theory	26	11.4%
Option 7: Many people criticize the system, but I feel that supporting it is the safest way to avoid chaos or negative consequences.	System Justification Theory	24	10.5%
Option 6: Corruption may be wrong, but sometimes it is necessary to make things work.	Moral disengagement	18	7.9%
Option 3: I do not expect other voters to withdraw their support for this reason, so my own behavior would not have any impact.	Collective action logic	13	5.7%

Note: Percentages exceed 100 because respondents could select more than one option.

6.4 Qualitative insights: narratives, emotions and complementary mechanisms

6.4.1 Narratives of corruption persistence

The primary word frequency count performed in Nvivo revealed that recurring references to institutional inadequacies were very prominent, with words like “system” (23), “politics” (20), “bureaucracy” (16),

and “services” (14), alongside terms indicating systemic shortcomings such as “lack” (20) appearing quite often. Additional references to “laws” (10) and “institutions” (8) further suggested the likely importance of institutional explanations. This was followed by terms related to cultural normalization, such as “culture” (20), “cultural” (13), “normal” (7), “rooted” (8), as well as “society” (11) and “social” (9), which suggested that corruption is often framed as a socially embedded and cultural phenomenon. Lastly, the words “education” (8) and “civic” (8) appeared quite often.

Based on this preliminary word frequency count and upon reading the material, subsequent coding and analysis led to the identification of two main themes, plus one overarching theme.

Institutional and bureaucratic inadequacy

The first theme to emerge was tied to respondents frequently describing corruption as a consequence of institutional and bureaucratic inadequacy. The mention of “slow” or “complex” bureaucracy was in fact very present, accompanied by the general perceived inefficiency of the state, both in providing public services and in providing protection.

Several respondents mentioned the law being inadequate, pointing out the “lack of clear rules”, as well as the fact that politicians cannot be held accountable, because they are protected by their own laws.

Closely related to this, was the idea of corruption as a pragmatic necessity or shortcut. Several stated that corruption persists because it represents a solution to bypass slow or complex bureaucratic processes. Others framed corruption as a necessity, underscoring that “if you want to obtain something important, it is the only way.”

What also appeared in the responses was the clear tendency for a good chunk of respondents to blame and attribute all responsibility to the “élite”, for instance with people saying that “it all starts with those at the top” and pointing out that “the first to be corrupt are those who should be eliminating corruption”, ultimately questioning how conceivable it is to hope to change things as long as politicians are corrupt. Others did acknowledge the role ordinary citizens can play in the perpetuation of corruption, for example by highlighting that “it is socially tolerated, and therefore there is no strong pressure on politics to counter this tendency”.

Cultural normalization

The second major theme concerned the description of corruption as historically rooted, culturally embedded and socially normalized. One respondent stated that corruption persists “because unfortunately it is rooted in our culture”, while another one described it as “a historical and cultural problem”. Others argued that it persists “because it is accepted by society”, with references to corruption being “the norm”

appearing multiple times. These framings often carried the implicit (and sometimes explicit) implication that corruption is *harder* to eradicate precisely because it is seen as long standing and normalized.

Some connected corruption to character/personality traits, such as “greed” and “laziness”, or “an innate desire to always outsmart others.” Others linked it to broader assumptions about Italian mentality, while others framed it more broadly as part of human nature. Lastly, multiple individuals mentioned the “lack of proper civic education” as a plausible reason as to why corruption remains persistent in Italy.

Overarching theme

Beyond the main themes, one overarching latent theme emerged: across responses, the generalized lack of trust in institutions coupled with the sense that corruption is culturally and socially embedded revealed a broader sense of resignation, with respondents appearing very little hopeful about improvement.

6.4.2 Emotional responses to corruption

The initial word frequency inquiry conducted in NVivo revealed that emotional responses to corruption were characterized by a wide range of negative affect. The most recurrent words were “anger” (17) and “angry” (21), followed by “powerless” (25). Words like “normality” (5), “indifferent” (4), “normal” (2), “normalized” (2), “resigned” (5), “discouraged” (2), “despair” (2) and “frustration” (4) further hinted a broader resignation theme. A series of other words pertaining to the realm of negative emotions followed, including “disappointed” (15), “sad” (10), “bad” (4), “discomfort” (5), as well as “disgust/disgusted” (10) and “ashamed” (6).

Based on this preliminary word frequency inquiry and subsequent qualitative coding, the analysis identified two main themes alongside an overarching latent theme.

Negative emotional reactions: anger, disgust and sadness

Multiple respondents described themselves as “angry” or “outraged” about being confronted with corruption. On a similar vein, many expressed “disgust” towards repeated scandals, demanding that corrupt actors be punished. Others, however, expressed a different kind of negative emotional reaction, referring to feeling sadness and disappointment about the state of things.

Normalization and emotional numbness: powerlessness, pessimism and resignation

Alongside anger, several respondents expressed feeling “powerless”, “discouraged” and “resigned”. One respondent summed it up by describing feeling like “my hands are tied”, referring to the perceived impossibility of action because of the circumstances.

Within this theme, once again one could discern lack of trust in the institutions, with respondents explicitly mentioned being “disappointed by the state”, feeling “betrayed” and “being aware that these people will often never be punished, except in exceptional cases.”

An additional pattern pointed to desensitization and normalization. Multiple individuals reported being “unsurprised”, “almost indifferent” or no longer emotionally touched by corruption scandals. Illustrative responses included for example a respondent saying that “it does not surprise me that much anymore, very often it is the norm.”

Contrasting emotions

Beyond the semantic content of individual responses, a broader latent theme emerged across the material: the coexistence of contrasting emotional orientations toward corruption.

As mentioned, anger was often accompanied by powerlessness, while disappointment could coexist with lack of surprise. Generally, responses indicated that corruption could provoke strong negative feelings and moral condemnation, while at the same time generating resignation. This pattern merged repeatedly, with participants declaring feeling “resigned and irritated,” “resigned and angry,” “discouraged and powerless,” or “indignant, but powerless.” A particularly illustrative example of this ambivalence is given by this respondent, who stated:

“I feel anger and frustration, but at the same time I feel as though I am defeated from the outset when trying to report what happened.” (Female, 18-24)

While contrasting emotions could coexist in a single person, some respondents appeared to embody more singular distinct orientations. One older participant, for example stated:

“I am still able to get angry; I am not desensitized, I still feel indignation” (Male, 66-75)

By contrast, a younger respondent wrote:

“By now I’m apathetic, it’s like talking about the weather” (Male, 18-24)

The two quotes point to two different orientations towards corruption: one characterized by continued indignation and potential willingness to react, the other by apathy and resignation. The contrast in age, particularly in relation to the previous finding showcasing that older groups were more likely to be willing to report corruption, ended up prompting further quantitative analysis of whether age predicts resignation. Using Q17 (belief that citizens can make a difference, rescaled to a 5-point metric) and Q18 (likelihood of reporting corruption, reverse coded so that higher values indicate greater resignation), a resignation index was created. Compared to respondents aged 18-24, those aged 56-65 scored significantly lower on resignation, as did those aged 66-75. After controlling for gender, education, and

ideology, the pattern remained. Older respondents therefore appeared less resigned, and more likely to believe that corruption can be challenged, suggesting once again that age appears as a consistent predictor within the sample under study.

Overall, the qualitative component of the study allowed to explore in which way respondents make sense of corruption and which emotions they associate with it. Responses converged on similar patterns and themes that emerged as especially salient. The next section integrates these qualitative findings with the qualitative results and returns to the broader research questions to discuss the main takeaways of the study.

7. Discussion

Acknowledging the layered complexity of CT

In line with the model proposed by (Bravo et al., 2025), findings offer support to the argument that CT is better understood as a multidimensional phenomenon (Bravo et al., 2025, p. 12-13). Across the analyses, dimensions of CT were not uniformly affected by the factors under study, suggesting that different dimensions might reflect different underlying psychological and social processes. Both GSJ and CP only significantly predicted normative tolerance and reported weak relationships with the other dimensions. In the case of CP, although these relationships should be interpreted with caution because of their limited statistical significance, variation in the direction of the relationships further suggested that its effects vary depending on how CT is conceptualized.

Besides aligning with (Bravo et al., 2025)'s concern that CT research often wrongly treats CT as a unidimensional phenomenon, these findings also somehow connect with the mixed results discussed in the literature review regarding the relationship between CP and CT. As highlighted, previous studies have often attributed ambiguous findings to individual-level and contextual factors. While that certainly remains true, the present findings raise the question of whether differences in conceptualization and operationalization of CT may also contribute to these inconsistencies. Broad claims regarding whether CP increases or decreases CT therefore become hard to make, because CT captures different outcomes depending on the studies. This type of reflection is supported by previous findings such as (Cameron et al., 2009)'s, who within the same study find that measuring tolerance in terms of likelihood to *engage* in corruption gives different results than measuring tolerance in terms of likelihood to *punish* corruption.

The complexity of CT does not only emerge across dimensions. Adding to the already layered complexity is the role context can play in shaping how tolerant a person might be towards corruption. Comparing responses across service types, findings indicate that certain situations, potentially those involving urgency or personal need (such as access to healthcare services), elicit higher levels of tolerance. More generally, this pattern supports the idea that corruption may be rationalized differently depending on situational pressures and level of “dependency” on the service.

Taken together, findings reinforce the importance of treating CT as a multidimensional and context-sensitive phenomenon, as well as the impact different and confused operationalizations of CT can have in assessing the state of the literature.

Beyond active endorsement of the status quo: exploring passive tolerance as a form of system justification

When it comes to the central inquiry of this thesis, namely whether SJT can provide a useful theoretical framework to understand CT, findings revealed a nuanced picture. While the quantitative analysis

provided little evidence of a strong relationship between GSJ and CT, qualitative findings complicated this interpretation.

The primary expectation derived from SJT would have suggested that stronger GSJ might be associated with greater CT. Under this scenario, tolerating corruption could function as a way of maintaining stability and reducing discomfort associated with challenging the status quo (J. T. Jost et al., 2019). However, findings provided no support for this expectation. GSJ significantly predicted only normative CT, while associations with attitudinal, intentional, practical, and behavioral tolerance remained mostly negative and statistically insignificant. This suggested that within the sample, GSJ did not make respondents personally more accepting of corruption or more willing to engage in it, instead, it reduced the extent to which they perceived corruption as socially accepted by others. This remains an interesting result, especially in light of social norms theory (N. Köbis et al., 2020), however it should be noted that it speaks more to perceptions regarding the broader social environment than to individual's own attitudes and behaviors.

(Tan et al., 2016)'s findings had led to formulate a competing expectation, namely that GSJ could lead people to have lower tolerance if corruption was perceived by them as a threat to the system. Once again, findings only provided limited support for this expectation. By finding mostly negative relationships, results partially aligned with (Tan et al., 2016), however no significant negative relationship with corruption intention was actually found in the present study (Tan et al., 2016, p. 4). Differences in operationalization, limited statistical power (due to the small sample size) as well as the fact that the Italian and Chinese context present several differences may account for this discrepancy.

Similarly, GSJ also did not seem to be a predictor of the paradox. Although insignificant, the relationship seemed to suggest that higher GSJ individuals were actually less likely to showcase inconsistencies between moral condemnation and behavioral willingness.

Arguably, the quantitative findings initially appeared to challenge the explanatory relevance of SJT. However, despite these results and most of the sample scoring low on GSJ, the qualitative answers suggested that SJ mechanisms were not to be ruled out completely. Indeed, if there's anything the qualitative analysis revealed, it is that people can cognitively condemn corruption, emotionally react negatively to it, yet feel resigned and compelled to just tolerate the system as it is.

As a reminder, Jost recognizes that "some cases of system justification are passive (and non-conscious) rather than active (and conscious)"(Jost, 2019, p. 279). In other words, under an SJT framework, individuals may justify the system either by going as far as to actively endorse the status quo or through more passive forms of SJ that resemble normalization and resignation. Clearly, the findings of this study appear more consistent with the latter.

Indeed, respondents rarely actively endorsed the system or expressed explicit approval of corruption (which was also reflected in the relatively low GSJ score observed in the sample), instead, many were rather critical about the system. Despite this, being critical was often accompanied by narratives emphasizing inevitability, powerlessness, and the perceived impossibility of meaningful change. Several of the "triggers" of SJ identified by Jost, such as perceiving the system as being inevitable, long-standing, or expressing feeling powerless (Jost, 2019, p. 267), repeatedly emerged throughout the qualitative answers.

More generally, some qualitative answers closely resembled ideas that are central to SJT. Quoting Gramsci, (Jost, 2019, p. 284) notes how the "great mass of people hesitate and lose heart when they think of what a radical change might bring. . . . [and] only imagine the present being torn to pieces" (Jost, 2019, p. 284). This very same idea emerged from a respondent's answer, who described that corruption persists:

"[b]ecause it is embedded in Italy to the very bone marrow; there are so many corrupt public officials that it becomes impossible to get rid of them all without tearing everything down and rebuilding from scratch. A fairer Italy is possible, but achieving it would require so much work that no one has the will, energy, or means to do it." (Male, 18-24, Emilia-Romagna)

From this perspective, the findings suggest the presence of what could be interpreted as SJ tendencies in part of the sample, not through active endorsement of the system, but through passive normalization and adaptation to a system that appears too difficult to change.

Importantly, this did only concern a portion of the sample, as several participants maintained strong anti-corruption positions declared willingness to oppose corruption. Passive SJ tendencies were far from universal, which also aligned with theoretical expectations acknowledging that SJ processes are not equally present across individuals (Kay and Friesen, 2011, p. 360) and that SJT is mainly about taking the "important exceptions seriously" (Jost et al., 2004, p. 883)

Overall, this points to the inadequacy of relying solely on quantitative measures when analyzing SJ in relation to CT. Had the study only relied on the quantitative analysis, the important distinction between conscious and more unconscious (passive) forms of SJ would have likely been missed. A point that is further exemplified by examining the profile of what could be described as the "archetype" of the paradox within the sample: one male respondent, aged 25-34, morally condemned corruption in the attitudinal items, yet stated he would make an unofficial payment in all four behavioral scenarios involving faster access to public service. Despite scoring relatively low on GSJ (2.63), several of his qualitative responses reflected forms of system-justifying reasoning, such as acknowledging corruption as wrong while still viewing it as sometimes necessary to "make things work."

Rather than a flaw in the GSJ scale, this case might point to the fact that GSJ does not capture passive forms of SJ. Individuals might be critical of the system while still willing to tolerate it as a way to navigate a system that is perceived as inefficient, yet entrenched, or unavoidable.

Alternative explanations

From the outset, the study acknowledged that CT is unlikely to be explained by a single theoretical framework, and that holistic approaches are to be favored. Therefore, the study also considered the salience of alternative explanations.

The vignette question allowed for a comparison between SJT-based explanations and competing explanations for CT. The analysis revealed that while system-justifying reasonings were present within the sample, they were not dominant. They were less salient than pragmatic and group interest reasoning, however they seemed more salient than moral disengagement and collective action logics. Ultimately, answers to this question further showed that, even though explicit GSJ effects were revealed to be modest, system-preserving reasoning still appeared in concrete political judgments and further reinforced the earlier conclusion that SJT does provide partial explanatory power.

At the same time, both the vignette responses and the qualitative findings highlighted the relevance of alternative explanations, particularly those related to institutional inefficiency, social normalization, and distrust in institutions. These patterns lend support to approaches anchored in social norms theories (N. C. Köbis et al., 2018), normalization theories (Fleming et al., 2022), institutional theories, and more rational theories that were touched upon in the literature review. In this sample, perceived institutional inefficiencies and consequent institutional distrust emerged as an especially salient theme, with several qualitative responses pointing at the relevance of a specific dynamic already identified by (Tan et al., 2016), whereby low trust in institutions appears to encourage more instrumental and pragmatic attitudes toward corruption (Tan et al., 2016, p. 3).

Lastly, also very interesting was the repeated salience of age as a predictor, more so than both GSJ, CP or any other socio-demographic factor. Across both intentional and practical dimensions, younger respondents displayed higher tolerance levels than older respondents, suggesting that generational differences may play a more important role than ideological system-justifying tendencies in shaping CT. At the same time, younger respondents also appeared to be more likely than older respondents to showcase the paradox as well as to be more resigned than their older counterparts.

Limitations and future avenues for research

Multiple limitations should be acknowledged in interpreting the findings of this study. First, the study does not provide direct evidence of SJ as a motivational process: although some narratives appeared consistent with passive forms of SJ, it remains impossible to determine whether respondents were

engaging in processes aimed at reducing uncertainty or palliate negative feeling. Rather, the qualitative narratives identified in this study resembled mechanisms proposed by SJT and may point toward processes worthy of further investigation.

Second, the small and non-representative sample undermined both generalizability and the extent to which results could be interpreted with confidence. Consequently, any finding should be interpreted cautiously and understood as exploratory. Relatedly, it should be noted that the Italian context is characterized by important regional differences that the sample could not capture. Access to services and experiences with institutional efficiency often vary between Northern and Southern Italy, potentially shaping forms of corruption tolerance and adaptation strategies. Since the majority of the sample was from northern Italy, it was not possible to investigate these potential differences meaningfully. Future research could better address this issue.

Third, even though age repeatedly came out as a consistent predictor, since the sample was disproportionately young, age-related findings should be interpreted with caution. That said, the repeated salience of age suggests that generational differences may represent an important avenue for future research, and the finding aligns with previous research identifying age effects in corruption-related attitudes (Torgler & Valev, 2006).

Fourth, the study also underscored the relevance of mixed methods design when studying corruption through a SJT framework by revealing drawbacks associated with approaching the study of CT purely from a quantitative perspective. However, the qualitative component of this study remained limited. Future research should further embrace qualitative approaches as well as explore alternative operationalization of SJ able to capture these dynamics more effectively.

Lastly, findings pointed to a possible avenue for future research which was already highlighted by (Bravo et al., 2025): the existence of a more affective or emotional dimension of CT. As the authors themselves note, their current typology is likely underrepresenting “more nuanced or qualitatively derived dimensions of corruption tolerance” (Bravo et al., 2025, p. 16). Future studies could therefore further explore whether a form of “emotional corruption tolerance” exists, potentially through SJT, characterized by a willingness to adapt/acquiesce to corruption dictated by feelings of powerlessness, resignation or need to maintain a sense of stability.

8. Conclusion

The broader aim of this thesis was to contribute to our understanding of the phenomenon of CT, specifically in light of the puzzling tension between widespread moral condemnation and tolerant attitudes and behaviors. Responding to recent calls for more rigorous approaches to CT and acknowledgement of its layered complexity (Bravo et al., 2025), the study employed SJT as its main theoretical framework and investigated whether system-justifying tendencies could help illuminate why citizens tolerate practices that ultimately disadvantage them. At the same time, it also strived to account for the relevance of complementary theories found in the literature. Italy served as theoretically relevant case through which these mechanisms could be explored.

Findings suggested that there is value in approaching CT as a multidimensional and context-specific phenomenon, as different dimensions were differently affected by predictors. Despite little evidence of GSJ being a predictor of CT, the broader usefulness of SJT as a lens through which to understand CT was not fully compromised by this result. While SJ in the form of active endorsement of the status quo was mostly absent, the integration of qualitative component revealed some evidence pointing to patterns consistent with passive forms of SJ. The study concludes that from a SJT perspective, such narratives may hide an underlying motivational process aimed at reducing uncertainty or adapting to a perceived inescapable system. While it is impossible to infer this with certitude, findings do nonetheless provide some evidence regarding the role emotions associated with corruption can play in shaping tolerant behavior, whether that be translated into simple passive adaptation or actual willingness to engage in corrupt acts. Consequently, results lend support to the idea that it is worth integrating underutilized socio-cognitive constructs, such as emotions, into the study of CT (Bravo et al., 2025, p. 15).

In terms of contributions, besides underscoring the value of approaching CT as a multidimensional phenomenon and SJT emerging as a promising analytical lens for understanding CT, from a methods point of view, the study supports the employment of mixed methods approaches and the integration of qualitative data in the study of CT.

More broadly, this body of work confirms something that is already known: CT is shaped by the interaction of several factors that operate at different levels. Rather than being a singular and straightforward phenomenon, CT is the result of interconnected psychological, social and contextual dynamics. In addition to socio-demographics factors and contextual factors, the present study highlighted the potential relevance of emotional processes in shaping corruption-related behaviors and attitudes. Further unpacking these mechanisms remains crucial, as designing effective anti-corruption strategies hinges on understanding under which conditions individuals come to tolerate corruption.

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Appendix A - Survey questionnaire (English) and variable mapping

Note: Due to the restructuring of the questionnaire presented in the Appendix, the variable names used in the dataset and do file do not correspond with the numbering displayed in the appendix questionnaire. Importantly, **analytical variable names reported throughout the thesis reflect the original dataset** and not the appendix numbers. The table provided in Appendix B serves as guide.

Appendix A1 - Survey questionnaire (English)

Attitudes and Perceptions of Corruption in Italy

This survey aims to examine the opinions, experiences, and perceptions of Italian citizens regarding corruption. The questionnaire is part of a Master's thesis project and takes approximately 10–15 minutes to complete.

Participation is voluntary and all responses are completely anonymous. No personally identifying information will be collected, and responses will be used exclusively for academic research purposes.

The study is intended for individuals aged 18 or older who hold Italian citizenship and currently reside in Italy. There are no right or wrong answers; please respond as honestly as possible.

Thank you for your time and contribution to this research.

Consent

Q1. Before proceeding, please confirm the following:

- I am 18 years old or older
- I am an Italian citizen and currently reside in Italy
- I voluntarily agree to participate in this study

Section A. Introductory demographic information

Q2. What is your age group?

- 18–24
- 25–34
- 35–44
- 45–55
- 56–65
- 66–75
- 76 or older

Q3. What is your gender?

- Male
- Female
- Non-binary / Other
- Prefer not to disclose

Q4. In which region of Italy do you currently reside?

- | | |
|-------------------------------------|--------------|
| • Piedmont | • Marche |
| • Aosta Valley | • Lazio |
| • Lombardy | • Abruzzo |
| • Liguria | • Molise |
| • Trentino-Alto Adige / South Tyrol | • Campania |
| • Veneto | • Puglia |
| • Friuli-Venezia Giulia | • Basilicata |
| • Emilia-Romagna | • Calabria |
| • Tuscany | • Sicily |
| • Umbria | • Sardinia |
-

General System Justification

Q5. Please indicate the extent to which you agree or disagree with the following statements.

Scale: 1 = Strongly disagree, 7 = Strongly agree

- Overall, I believe that society is fair.
 - The Italian political system functions as it should.
 - Italian society needs to be fundamentally restructured.
 - Italy is the best country in which to live.
 - Most public policies serve the common good.
 - Everyone has equal opportunities to achieve success.
 - Society is getting worse every year.
 - People generally get what they deserve.
-

Perceptions and experiences of corruption

Q6. How widespread do you think corruption is in Italy?

- Very widespread
- Fairly widespread
- Neither widespread nor rare
- Fairly rare
- Very rare
- Don't know

Q7. In your opinion, how acceptable is corruption to most Italians?

- Not at all acceptable
- Slightly acceptable
- Moderately acceptable
- Quite acceptable
- Completely acceptable
- Don't know

Q8. In the past 12 months, have you personally been asked to offer a gift, favor, or payment in exchange for a public service?

- Yes
 - No
 - Don't know
-

Corruption tolerance

Q9. Imagine that you need one of the following public services and that someone suggests that a small unofficial payment could speed up the process or make it easier. In each case, how likely would you be to make such a payment?

Scale: 1 = Extremely unlikely, 5 = Extremely likely

- Healthcare services (e.g., access to treatment in public hospitals, diagnostic tests)
- Administrative permits and procedures (e.g., building permits, business licenses, bureaucratic authorizations)
- Educational services (e.g., exam registration, enrollment, grade management)
- Official documents and certifications (e.g., identity documents, vehicle registration, certificates)

Q10. In your opinion, how justifiable is it for a public official to accept a gift or money in exchange for providing or expediting the following public services?

Scale: 1 = Not at all justifiable, 5 = Completely justifiable

- Healthcare services
- Administrative permits and procedures
- Educational services
- Official documents and certifications

Q11. In some situations, people may feel that informal payments or favors are the only way to obtain an important public service. In such cases, how acceptable do you consider this behavior?

Scale: 1 = Completely unacceptable, 5 = Completely acceptable

- Healthcare services
- Administrative permits and procedures
- Educational services
- Official documents and certifications

Q12. People are sometimes encouraged to make unofficial payments to speed up or facilitate access to public services. If this were to happen in the following situations, what would you be most likely to do?

- I would pay
- I would refuse
- I would refuse and report the incident to the relevant authorities
- I would try to obtain the service in another way
- Not sure

(For each of the following:)

- Healthcare services
 - Administrative permits and procedures
 - Educational services
 - Official documents and certifications
-

Civic Attitudes and reporting

Q13. Please indicate whether you agree or disagree with the following statement:

“Ordinary people can make a difference in the fight against corruption.”

- Agree
- Neither agree nor disagree
- Disagree

Q14. If you became aware of a case of corruption involving a public official, how likely would you be to take action (e.g., report it, sign a petition, or participate in a protest)?

- Extremely unlikely
- Fairly unlikely
- Neither likely nor unlikely
- Fairly likely
- Extremely likely

Q15. In your opinion, what are the main reasons why people may choose not to report corruption? (Select all that apply)

- Difficulty in proving the incident
 - Reporting would be ineffective because those responsible would not be punished
 - Lack of protection against retaliation
 - Not knowing where or how to report
 - Reluctance to report others
 - General awareness that corruption exists, but no one reports it
 - Fear of negative consequences for whistleblowers
 - Other (please specify)
-

Open-ended questions

Q16. In your opinion, why does corruption persist in Italy?

Q17. How do you feel when you hear about corruption scandals or encounter corruption in your daily life?

Alternative explanations

Q18. In many countries, voters continue to support politicians even when they are accused of corruption. This may occur for various reasons.

Imagine that a politician you support becomes involved in a corruption scandal. Which of the following reasons might lead you to continue supporting them?

- The politician has achieved positive results, which matter more to me than corruption allegations
 - Replacing the politician could jeopardize essential services I rely on
 - I do not expect other voters to withdraw support, so my behavior would not make a difference
 - The politician represents my interests or political group
 - Maintaining political stability is more important than addressing corruption
 - Corruption may be wrong, but it is sometimes necessary for things to function
 - Supporting the system feels safer than risking instability or negative consequences
 - Other (please specify)
-

Additional socioeconomic and background information

Q19. What is the highest level of education you have completed?

- No formal education
- Primary education
- Lower secondary education
- Upper secondary education (high school diploma)
- Vocational qualification
- Bachelor's degree or equivalent
- Master's degree or equivalent
- Postgraduate specialization
- PhD
- Prefer not to disclose

Q20. What is your current employment status?

- Full-time employed
- Part-time employed
- Self-employed / freelancer
- Unemployed (seeking work)
- Unemployed (not seeking work)
- Retired
- Homemaker
- Student
- Prefer not to disclose

Q21. What is your household's monthly income (before taxes)?

- Less than €1,000
- €1,000–1,999
- €2,000–2,999
- €3,000–3,999
- €4,000–4,999
- €5,000–6,999
- €7,000 or more
- Don't know
- Prefer not to disclose

Q22. What is your current religious affiliation, if any?

- Catholic
- Protestant

- Orthodox
- Muslim
- Jewish
- Hindu
- Buddhist
- Other religion
- No religious affiliation / atheist / agnostic
- Prefer not to disclose

Q23. How would you describe your political orientation?

- Very progressive / liberal
- Moderately progressive / liberal
- Centrist / moderate
- Moderately conservative
- Very conservative
- Prefer not to disclose

Q24. Do you know which of the following positions Antonio Tajani currently holds?

- President of the European Parliament
 - Deputy Prime Minister and Minister of Foreign Affairs
 - Member of the European Parliament
 - Mayor of Rome
 - Don't know / Prefer not to disclose
-

Closing

Thank you for completing the survey.

To finalize the submission of your responses, please proceed to the next page.

You are also encouraged to share this survey with others. Each response is valuable and contributes to the research.

If you are willing to further discuss your responses, you may participate in a short online or telephone interview. Please follow this link and provide your email address:

https://samgu.eu.qualtrics.com/jfe/form/SV_6kSIGBMEKCzCW3Q

Appendix A2 – Variable Mapping

Dataset and analysis variables names	Corresponding Appendix questionnaire item
Q5_GSJ_* / GSJ_index	Q5
Q9_corruption_perception / corrup_diffusion_clean	Q6
Q10_acceptability / corrupt_normative_clean	Q7
Q11_exposure	Q8
Q12_intent_* / corrup intent	Q9
Q12_attitude_* / corrupt_attitude	Q10
Q14_practical_* / corrupt_practical	Q11
Q15_behavior_* / corrupt_behavior	Q12
Q17_fight_corruption_belief	Q13
Q18_reaction_report	Q14
Q_19*	Q15
Q21_open_corruption_belief	Q16
Q22_emotional_response	Q17
Q23_support_reason_*	Q18
Q24_education	Q19
Q25_employment	Q20
Q26_income	Q21
Q27_religion	Q22
Q28_political_view	Q23
Q29_Tajani	Q24

Appendix B - Detailed information on the sampling strategy

Good sampling happens when all members of the population of interest have the exact same chance of being picked to answer the survey, and this most likely happens by relying on probability methods rather than non-probability methods (Fowler, 2009, p. 16). For a study aiming at capturing attitudes within the population of Italy (around 59 million as of early 2026, considering only adults only 50 millions) this would involve a large, randomly selected and stratified sample to ensure maximum representativeness (Creswell, 2014, pp. 203–205). For a 95% confidence level, using random sampling and aiming for a $\pm 5\%$ margin of error, a baseline of 385 respondents would have been a good enough baseline for this project (*Sage Research Methods - Survey Research Methods (4th Ed.)*, n.d.)(Creswell, 2014, p. p.205).

Unfortunately, due to time and resource constraints typical of a master thesis, the study employs a non-probability sample approach. More specifically, a combination of convenience and snowball sampling was used. Data were collected via a self-administered online survey hosted on Qualtrics, a popular online survey tool (Creswell and Hirose, 2019, p. 3). Prior to distribution, the survey was pretested to identify potential issues related to clarity and completion time (Fowler, 2009, p. 17). The test revealed that it took a lot longer than anticipated, so minor revisions were performed to reduce length. Following these adjustments response time fell into the 10-15 minute window desired.

Distribution officially started March 18th 2026 and lasted until mid-April. A mix of approaches were used to distribute the survey, including outreach to apolitical civil society organizations with nationwide coverage, targeted dissemination through university networks, social media platforms (Facebook, WhatsApp and LinkedIn) as well as personal contacts. After one week of the survey being out, 157 responses had been gathered, with a noticeable overrepresentation of respondents from Northern Italy. A second round of distribution was initiated, including follow-up emails and targeted messages to universities and civil society organizations in Southern Italy. By April 7th 270 responses had been registered. The survey remained open longer with the hope of increasing participation among underrepresented groups, particularly respondents from southern Italy and those identifying as politically conservative. Despite efforts, the final sample remained somewhat unbalanced and not highly representative of the Italian population. The implications tied to this limitation are discussed and acknowledged.

Appendix C - Variables operationalization and construction

Corresponding Appendix questionnaire item	Variable name	<u>Concept/construct</u> Operationalization/coding (referring to original survey items' numbers)	Range	Role
Q5	GSJ_index	<u>General System Justification</u> Mean of 8 GSJ items; negatively worded items reverse-coded	1-7	Main IV
Q10	corrupt_attitude	<u>Attitudinal CT</u> Mean of four attitudinal scenario items (Q13)	1-5	DV
Q9	corrupt_intent	<u>Intentional CT</u> Mean of four intentional scenario items (Q12)	1-5	DV
Q11	corrupt_practical	<u>Practical CT</u> Mean of four practical scenario items (Q14)	1-5	DV
Q7	corrupt_normative_clean	<u>Normative CT</u> Q10 acceptability item; "Don't know" excluded	1-5	DV
Q12	corrupt_behavior	<u>Behavioral CT</u> Binary behavioral corruption tolerance variable derived from Q15 Scenario 1. Respondents willing to make an unofficial payment were coded as 1, while those choosing refusal or alternative actions were coded as 0. "Don't know" responses were excluded. Unlike the other CT dimensions, this variable was operationalized as binary because the item captures a concrete behavioral choice rather than varying degrees of tolerance. On top of that, only Scenario 1 was retained because the remaining behavioral scenarios displayed extremely limited variation, with willingness to engage remaining below 4% across scenarios, thereby providing insufficient behavioral differentiation for regression analysis.	0/1	DV
Q12	behav1-behav4	<u>Scenario-specific behavioral CT</u> Recoded scenario-specific binary behavioral corruption variables derived from Q15. Respondents willing to make an unofficial payment were coded as 1, while refusal or alternative actions were coded as 0. Used descriptively to compare behavioral tolerance across contexts.	0/1	Descriptive (not used in regressions, only to assess contextual differences)
Q6	corrupt_diffusion_clean	<u>Corruption perception</u> Q9 perceived prevalence of corruption; "don't know" excluded; recoded so higher = more widespread	1-5	IV
*Q10 recoded	moral_condemn	<u>Moral condemnation</u> A binary variable for <i>moral condemnation</i> was created based on attitudinal tolerance (Q13), where respondents who strongly condemned corruption were coded as 1, and all others as 0.	0/1	Construct
*Based on Q10 recoded and Q12	paradox_clean	<u>Norm-practice paradox</u> 1 = morally condemns corruption but still willing to engage behaviorally; 0 = morally condemns corruption and unwilling to engage; restricted to valid behavioural responses	0/1	DV
Q2	Q4_age_group	<u>Age</u> Self-reported age group	Categorical	Control
Q3	Q5_gender	<u>Gender</u> Self-reported gender	Categorical	Control
Q19	Q24_education	<u>Education</u> Self-reported highest level of education	Categorical	Control

Q23	Q28_political_view	<u>Political orientation</u> Self-placement on political spectrum	Categorical	Control
*Q23 recoded	pol_progressive	<u>Political orientation recode</u> 1 = progressive/liberal; 0 = moderate; conservative categories excluded because of sparse data	0/1	Control/TV
Q21	Q26_income	<u>Household income</u> Self-reported monthly household income category	Categorical	Control
Q14	Q18_reaction_report	<u>Anti-corruption action</u> Self-reported likelihood of taking action against corruption	1-5	DV
Mean of Q13 and Q14	resignation_index	<u>Resignation towards corruption</u> Mean of Q17 (belief that ordinary citizens can make a difference, rescaled from 3-point to 5-point scale) and reversed Q18 (likelihood of taking action); higher values indicate greater resignation and lower perceived efficacy against corruption	1-5	Exploratory DV
Q18	Q23_support_reason_*	<u>Support for alternative explanations for CT</u> Multiple-response vignette items assessing reasons for supporting a corrupt incumbent. 1 = respondent selected that explanation, 0 = respondent did not select it.	0/1 (per option)	Descriptive frequencies

Digression on the operationalization of behavioral tolerance

Unlike attitudinal, intentional and practical tolerance, the behavioral dimensions could not be operationalized through a continuous index capturing degrees of tolerance. While the other dimensions were measured through Likert types capturing degrees of tolerance that naturally allowed for the construction of continuous indexes, the behavioral item captured a concrete behavioral decision and required a different approach.

On top of that, analysis revealed that the four behavioral scenarios showed extreme sparsity. Willingness to engage in corrupt behavior remained below 4% in three of the four scenarios, with only Scenario 1 displaying more substantial variation (13.4%). The risk was that by aggregating the four behavioral scenarios into one, the index would produce a variable heavily compressed around zero with very limited interpretive value. For this reason, retaining only Scenario 1 for the regressions was analytically preferable. Even though averaging behavioral scenarios would have increased symmetry with the other CT dimensions, it would also have dramatically reduced variation, weakened statistical interpretability, and potentially obscured meaningful behavioral differences.

That said, in order to investigate contextual differences in behavioral tolerance, four separate scenario-based binary indicators (behav1–behav4) were created and analyzed descriptively. This allowed for comparison of behavioral willingness across contexts while preserving the greater behavioral differentiation observed in Scenario 1 for the regression analyses.

Appendix D - Descriptive statistics and reliability

Table D1 Descriptive statistics of main variables

Descriptive Statistics of Main Variables

	N	Mean	SD	Min	Max
General System Justification (GSJ)	273	2.92	0.866	1	5.5
Attitudinal CT	261	1.236	0.548	1	4
Intentional CT	261	1.971	0.962	1	5
Practical CT	254	1.624	0.820	1	4.25
Normative CT	249	2.924	0.970	1	5
Behavioral CT	224	.134	0.341	0	1
Corruption perception	257	4.062	0.788	1	5
Resignation index	250	2.058	0.951	1	5

Note: Higher values indicate greater levels of the measured construct. Behavioral corruption tolerance is coded as a binary variable (1 = willingness to engage in corruption; 0 = unwillingness). Missing “I don’t know” responses were excluded where applicable.

Table D2 Reliability of Multi-Item Scales

Scale	Number of items	Cronbach’s α
GSJ Index	8	0.77
Intentional CT	4	0.86
Attitudinal CT	4	0.87
Practical CT	4	0.89

Note: Cronbach’s alpha coefficients are based on the items used to construct each scale. Reverse-coded GSJ items were recoded before reliability testing.

Table D3 Descriptive Statistics for Corruption Tolerance Dimension

Variable	N	Mean	SD	Min	Max
Normative CT	249	2.92	0.97	1	5
Intentional CT	261	1.97	0.96	1	5
Practical CT	254	1.62	0.82	1	4.25
Attitudinal CT	261	1.24	0.55	1	4
Behavioral CT	224	0.13	0.34	0	1

Notes: Higher values indicate greater corruption tolerance. Behavioral tolerance is coded as a binary variable (1 = willingness to engage in corruption; 0 = no willingness to engage in corruption), so its mean represents the proportion of respondents willing to engage in corruption (13.4%).

Table D4 Corruption Tolerance across service contexts

Service context	Intentional CT (Mean)	Attitudinal CT (Mean)	Practica CT (Mean)	Behavioral CT (%)
Healthcare services (Scenario 1)	2.52	1.34	1.94	13.4%
Permits and administrative procedures (Scenario 2)	1.87	1.18	1.49	3.7%
Educational services (Scenario 3)	1.70	1.18	1.50	3.3%
Official documents and certifications (Scenario 4)	1.80	1.24	1.58	3.7%

Notes: Higher values indicate greater corruption tolerance. Behavioral tolerance is based on binary indicators coded 1 = willingness to engage in corruption and 0 = no willingness; values are therefore interpretable as proportions (reported here as percentages).

Table D5 Moral condemnation and behavioral willingness to engage in corruption

	No behavioral willingness (0)	Behavioral willingness (1)	Total
Does not strongly condemn corruption (0)	64.7% (11)	35.5% (6)	7.6% (17)
Strongly condemns corruption (1)	88.4% (183)	11.6% (24)	92.4% (207)
Total	86.6% (194)	13.4% (30)	100% 224

Notes: Row percentages reported. Behavioral willingness refers to the binary behavioral tolerance measure (corrupt_behavior). Moral condemnation is based on the attitudinal tolerance index, where lower scores indicate stronger condemnation of corruption.

Appendix E - Full regression analyses and supplementary regression models

Table E1 Full models: GSJ and Corruption Tolerance

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	Attitudinal	Intentional	Practical	Normative	Behavioral (logit)
GSJ_index	0.076 (0.042)	-0.082 (0.075)	-0.030 (0.064)	-0.290** (0.088)	-0.318 (0.296)
Age					
25-34	0.102 (0.151)	-0.002 (0.189)	-0.145 (0.186)	0.028 (0.192)	-0.103 (0.558)
35-44	-0.058 (0.142)	-0.442 (0.270)	-0.153 (0.259)	-0.285 (0.219)	Omitted
45-55	-0.091 (0.170)	-0.428* (0.215)	-0.402* (0.181)	-0.247 (0.254)	-0.828 (0.734)
56-65	-0.125 (0.079)	-0.790*** (0.159)	-0.657*** (0.141)	-0.381 (0.210)	-2.392* (1.075)
66-75	0.009 (0.150)	-0.801*** (0.186)	-0.691*** (0.188)	-0.663* (0.300)	-0.747 (0.861)
76+	-0.138 (0.103)	-1.069*** (0.246)	-0.864*** (0.170)	0.019 (0.475)	Omitted
Gender					
Female	-0.015 (0.071)	-0.079 (0.120)	-0.065 (0.110)	0.206 (0.132)	-0.086 (0.450)
Prefer not to disclose	0.327 (0.192)	1.526*** (0.322)	-0.697 (0.359)	0.621 (0.404)	Omitted
Education					
Upper secondary education	0.056 (0.088)	0.160 (0.272)	-0.368 (0.258)	-0.107 (0.433)	-1.057 (0.990)
Vocational qualification	0.070 (0.157)	0.253 (0.461)	-0.763* (0.346)	0.211 (0.461)	-0.536 (1.242)
Bachelor's degree	0.186 (0.132)	-0.029 (0.298)	-0.407 (0.277)	0.107 (0.439)	-1.122 (0.998)
Master's degree	0.047 (0.084)	-0.120 (0.270)	-0.523* (0.264)	0.013 (0.435)	-1.188 (1.022)
Post-graduate specialization	0.362 (0.290)	0.004 (0.328)	-0.440 (0.310)	-0.274 (0.507)	Omitted
PhD	-0.083 (0.132)	-0.771** (0.284)	-0.618 (0.370)	0.210 (0.484)	Omitted

Prefer not to disclose	-0.074 (0.166)	0.039 (0.645)	-0.796* (0.347)	0.826 (0.538)	Omitted
Political orientation					
Moderately progressive/ liberal	0.195* (0.086)	0.195 (0.146)	0.142 (0.138)	0.213 (0.169)	0.123 (0.661)
Centrist / Moderate	0.227* (0.094)	0.487** (0.179)	0.066 (0.156)	0.241 (0.196)	0.973 (0.698)
Moderately conservative	-0.168 (0.125)	-0.050 (0.212)	-0.271 (0.246)	1.101* (0.433)	Omitted
Very conservative	0.144 (0.137)	0.954 (0.552)	-0.468* (0.221)	-0.176 (0.338)	Omitted
Prefer not to disclose	0.232* (0.111)	0.521* (0.215)	0.383* (0.163)	0.012 (0.247)	0.815 (0.748)
Constant	0.789*** (0.134)	2.235*** (0.330)	2.365*** (0.304)	3.694*** (0.482)	0.303 (1.279)
Observations	235	235	235	225	176
R-squared	0.104	0.234	0.174	0.190	
Pseudo R-squared					0.104

Notes: Robust standard errors in parentheses. Models 1-4 estimated with OLS regression; Model 5 estimated with logistic regression. Some categories in Model 5 were omitted because of sparse data and perfect prediction. Reference categories: Age = 18–24; Gender = Male; Education = Lower secondary education; Political orientation = Very progressive/liberal.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table E2 Full models: GSJ and the Norm-Practice Paradox

	(1) Bivariate	(2) Controlled
paradox_clean		
GSJ_index	-0.336 (0.272)	-0.331 (0.323)
Age		
25-34		-0.685 (0.629)
35-44		Omitted
45-55		-0.794 (0.691)
56-65		-2.310* (1.063)
66-75		-0.596 (0.795)
76+		Omitted
Gender		
Female		0.069 (0.482)

Prefer not to disclose	Omitted
Political orientation	
Moderately progressive / liberal	-0.108
	(0.655)
Centrist / Moderate	0.793
	(0.693)
Moderately conservative	Omitted
Very conservative	Omitted
Prefer not to disclose	1.088
	(0.757)
Constant	-1.101
	(0.760)
	-0.781
	(0.916)
Observations	207
	171
Pseudo R-squared	0.011
	0.094

Notes: Robust standard errors in parentheses. Model 2 controls for age, gender, and political orientation. Some categories in Model 2 were omitted because of sparse data and perfect prediction. Both models estimated using logistic regression. Reference categories: Age = 18–24; Gender = Male; Political orientation = Very progressive/ liberal. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table E3. Full Models: Corruption Perception and Corruption Tolerance

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	Attitudinal	Intentional	Practical	Normative	Behavioral (logit)
Corruption perception	-0.079	0.050	-0.008	0.366***	-0.228
	(0.065)	(0.087)	(0.075)	(0.088)	(0.269)
Age					
25-34	0.124	-0.053	-0.140	-0.053	-0.107
	(0.152)	(0.190)	(0.190)	(0.184)	(0.559)
35-44	-0.075	-0.410	-0.156	-0.235	Omitted
	(0.145)	(0.270)	(0.267)	(0.245)	
45-55	-0.088	-0.441*	-0.394*	-0.174	-0.698
	(0.175)	(0.218)	(0.188)	(0.217)	(0.715)
56-65	-0.102	-0.817***	-0.670***	-0.468*	-2.597*
	(0.078)	(0.162)	(0.140)	(0.204)	(1.097)
66-75	0.050	-0.867***	-0.690***	-0.748**	-0.913
	(0.150)	(0.188)	(0.191)	(0.266)	(0.924)
76+	-0.160	-1.045***	-0.870***	0.106	Omitted
	(0.110)	(0.237)	(0.170)	(0.502)	
Gender					
Female	-0.008	-0.071	-0.062	0.156	0.023
	(0.071)	(0.119)	(0.111)	(0.129)	(0.454)
Prefer not to disclose	0.300	1.550***	-0.607	0.648	Omitted
	(0.206)	(0.274)	(0.346)	(0.423)	

Education					
Upper secondary education	0.028	0.136	-0.372	0.121	-0.923
	(0.077)	(0.265)	(0.265)	(0.451)	(0.917)
Vocational qualification	0.075	0.209	-0.758*	0.264	-0.133
	(0.162)	(0.464)	(0.346)	(0.474)	(1.179)
Bachelor's degree	0.161	-0.049	-0.423	0.292	-1.019
	(0.131)	(0.296)	(0.286)	(0.459)	(0.927)
Master's degree	-0.000	-0.127	-0.528	0.328	-0.986
	(0.085)	(0.268)	(0.269)	(0.454)	(0.965)
Post-graduate specialization	0.332	-0.014	-0.463	-0.050	0.000
	(0.280)	(0.326)	(0.312)	(0.540)	Omitted
PhD	-0.132	-0.745**	-0.645	0.475	
	(0.128)	(0.284)	(0.372)	(0.539)	Omitted
Prefer not to disclose	0.033	-0.459	-0.712	0.942	
	(0.229)	(0.661)	(0.387)	(0.599)	Omitted
Political orientation					
Moderately progressive / liberal	0.221**	0.185	0.123	0.083	0.004
	(0.084)	(0.140)	(0.135)	(0.155)	(0.627)
Centrist / Moderate	0.259*	0.477**	0.038	0.070	0.810
	(0.101)	(0.173)	(0.150)	(0.174)	(0.646)
Moderately conservative	-0.178	-0.044	-0.315	1.144**	Omitted
	(0.147)	(0.220)	(0.245)	(0.383)	
Very conservative	0.192	0.917	-0.461*	-0.389	Omitted
	(0.155)	(0.520)	(0.226)	(0.354)	
Prefer not to disclose	0.236*	0.567**	0.346*	-0.083	0.594
	(0.120)	(0.209)	(0.165)	(0.239)	(0.696)
_cons	1.327***	1.821***	2.338***	1.303*	0.272
	(0.302)	(0.517)	(0.471)	(0.642)	(1.420)
Observations	232	232	232	224	174
R-squared	0.103	0.238	0.169	0.218	-
Pseudo R-squared	-	-	-	-	0.098

Notes: Robust standard errors in parentheses. All models control for age, gender, education, and political orientation. Reference categories: Age = 18–24; Gender = Male; Political orientation = Very progressive/liberal. Corruption perception operationalized as perceived corruption prevalence (corruption_perception_clean). Some categories in Model 5 were omitted because of sparse data and perfect prediction. Models 1–4 estimated with OLS regression; Model 5 estimated with logistic regression.
 $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table E4 Predictors of GSJ

	(1) GSJ index
pol_progressive	-0.263 (0.138)
Age	
25-34	0.131 (0.166)
35-44	0.329 (0.286)
45-55	0.159 (0.203)
56-65	0.370 (0.193)
66-75	0.497 (0.257)
76+	0.00512 (0.414)
Gender	
Female	-0.163 (0.131)
Education	
Upper secondary education	0.604 (0.385)
Vocational qualification	0.658 (0.688)
Bachelor's degree	0.833* (0.382)
Master's degree	0.672 (0.389)
Post-graduate spezialization	1.160** (0.433)
PhD	0.698 (0.472)
Prefer not to disclose	2.836*** (0.403)
Constant	2.296*** (0.395)
Observations	192

Notes: Robust standard errors in parentheses.

Reference categories: Age = 18–24; Gender = Male;

Education = Lower secondary education; Political orientation = Moderate. * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$

Table E5 GSJ and willingness to report corruption

	(1) Q18 reaction report
GSJ_index	0.0396 (0.0997)
Age	
25-34	0.340 (0.213)
35-44	0.600 (0.313)
45-55	0.252 (0.331)
56-65	0.597** (0.195)
66-75	0.376 (0.282)
76+	0.583 (0.414)
Gender	
Female	0.239 (0.151)
Education	
Upper secondary education	-0.269 (0.448)
Vocational qualification	0.193 (0.489)
Bachelor's degree	0.000833 (0.475)
Master's degree	-0.0618 (0.455)
Postgraduate specialization	-0.0774 (0.517)
PhD	-0.355 (0.864)
Prefer not to disclose	-0.903 (0.560)
Political orientation	
Progressive	0.364 (0.185)
_cons	3.001*** (0.554)
<i>N</i>	192

Notes: Robust standard errors in parentheses. Reference categories: Age = 18–24; Gender = Male; Education = Lower secondary education; Political orientation = Moderate. * $p < .05$, ** $p < .01$, *** $p < .001$

Appendix F - Qualitative Codebook

Table G1 Coding framework question 1: Why does corruption persist in Italy?

Theme	Code	Definition	Illustrative quotes
Institutional and bureaucratic inadequacy	Slow bureaucracy	Corruption attributed as a consequence of slow bureaucracy	"Socio-cultural factors, unreliability/lack of trust, complex bureaucracy"; "The clientelistic nature of politics, the slowness of bureaucracy, and the lack of adequate oversight"; "Bureaucratic inefficiency that public officials take advantage of because they can profit from it"; "The complexity of bureaucratic processes"
	Weak legal framework	Corruption linked to inadequate laws, controls and sanctions	"Because politicians cannot be punished; they are protected by their own laws!"; "Lack of clear regulations"; "Too few anti-corruption laws; deficiencies in public services that leave people exhausted and willing to do anything to obtain what they need; insufficient awareness, especially in schools"; "Lengthy judicial processes and an excessively slow justice system"
	Political élites	Responsibility and blame put on political actors and the government	"It all starts from the top"; "Because there are corrupt individuals at the highest levels of government"; "If the government itself is corrupt, how can corruption ever end?"; "The first people to be corrupt are those who should be eliminating corruption"
	Lack of trust in institution	Lack of perceived help coming from the state, fear of consequences when challenging corruption	"Ignorance, fear of retaliation, and not feeling sufficiently protected by law enforcement"; "Fear of retaliation"
	Pragmatic shortcut/necessity	Corruption framed as a practical way to bypass inefficient institutions and services	"Because I get what I need immediately"; "Because it is a convenient situation for most people"; "Italians (sometimes myself included) find it to be a more convenient and faster solution for obtaining what they want and, consequently, prefer to have everything immediately rather than go through endless bureaucratic procedures"; "Because if you want to obtain something important, it is the only way"; "Because it is so deeply rooted that it often seems like the only option, and it is not really a taboo or viewed as something evil; rather, it is seen as a means to achieve an end"
Cultural normalization	Historical and cultural embeddedness	Corruption framed as rooted in history and culturally embedded	"It is a historical and cultural problem"; "These are practices rooted in Italian culture that are difficult to change"; "Culture (that is, the normalization of the use of this practice), lack of adequate oversight"; "Historical legacy and power system: since the birth of the Republic, the management of power (particularly during the long period of Christian Democracy) has often favored mediation practices that have 'blurred' the boundaries"; "A systemic problem that seems too large to do anything concrete about"; "A system rooted over time that is not easy to solve"; "These are practices rooted in Italian culture that are difficult to change"

	Social normalization	Corruption described as socially accepted	"Because it is accepted by society"; "Because it is widely accepted by many people and considered normal for accessing certain services, and those who engage in corruption are not adequately punished or sanctioned by the judicial system"; "It is socially tolerated, and therefore there is a lack of strong pressure on politics to counter this tendency; "Corruption is so widespread that even targeting a single point will not truly change anything. It is like a tumor."
	Character traits	Corruption linked to greed, laziness, opportunism or assumption tied to "Italian mentality"	"An innate need to always be smarter than others"; "Because people are greedy and selfish"; "Greed"; "Laziness"; "Greed, power, excessive profits"; "Because people are more easygoing and less strict about rules and do not worry too much about them"; "There is an opportunistic mentality because people think they live in a struggling country and therefore believe it is better to be among those who take advantage rather than those who are taken advantage of"; "The lack of seriousness among us Italians"; "It is something deeply rooted in the Italian mentality; in the end, it is seen as 'just a small favor' that does not really harm anyone"
	Human nature	Corruption framed as part of human nature	"It is a natural phenomenon in general and must be fought against. It is part of human weaknesses and the distorted values of human beings"; "Corruption is a problem present in all societies, not only in Italian society; bureaucracy and poor public services can often be among the factors that allow corruption to continue to exist"
	Lack of civic education	Corruption attributed to limited civic awareness	"Moral and social decline, lack of education, and lack of awareness of one's rights"; "An underdeveloped civic culture and state institutions that are often inefficient and under-resourced"; "Lack of civic education regarding corruption"; "Insufficient oversight by institutions and other competent authorities; inadequate civic education in schools"; "Poor civic education, resignation among people, and the persistence of mafia organizations at all levels"

Overarching latent theme: Resignation

Table F2 Coding framework question 2: How do you feel when you hear about corruption scandals or encounter corruption in your daily life?

Theme	Code	Definition	Illustrative quotes
Negative emotional responses	Anger/outrage	Expression of anger and indignation towards corruption	"Angry"; "I get really angry"; "Angry because the law is not respected"; "Anger and disappointment"; "Indignant, but powerless"
	Disgust	Expression of moral revulsion toward corruption	"Disappointed"; "Disappointed and angry"; "Frustrated, disappointed in my country, but not surprised"
	Sadness/disappointment	Feelings of sadness and discouragement regarding corruption and its consequences	"Sad"; "Sad, dejected, powerless"; "Disappointed"; "Disappointed and angry"; "Frustrated, disappointed in my country, but not surprised"
	Shame	Shame associated with corruption happening in their country	"I am ashamed to be part of this society"; "I feel a slight sense of shame for my country and concern about the possible recurrence of these situations in the future"; "I am ashamed to be Italian"
Normalization and emotional numbness	Powerlessness	Perceived inability to meaningfully challenge corruption	"Powerless"; "Discouraged and powerless"; "Anger and powerlessness, because in the long run everything will be forgotten"; "Powerless and disgusted"; "Unable to do anything"; "With my hands tied"
	Resignation	Acceptance of corruption due to resignation	"Resigned and irritated"; "Resigned and angry"; "I feel anger and frustration, but at the same time I feel defeated from the outset in trying to report what happened."
	Lack of surprise	Corruption perceived as expected or ordinary	"It does not surprise me that much anymore; very often it is the norm"; "By now the mind is almost used to it; it is normalized far too much"; "Not very surprised, but also not very interested"; "Disgust, but it is normal"; "Disillusioned, resigned, and sarcastically 'amused' by some people's surprise...";
	Apathy /Indifference	Emotional detachment and desensitization towards corruption	"Indifferent"; "Indifference, it happens often"; "Unfortunately, I do not feel too affected by it; in Italy it is almost normalized. It feels strange to think that someone is not corrupt, especially when talking about public institutions"; "Indifferent, and I think there are people who have it worse"; "By now apathetic; it is like talking about the weather"; "Almost indifferent, given the Italian situation"; "Almost used to it"

Overarching latent theme: Contrasting emotion

Appendix G - Stata Do-File

```
*=====

* THESIS ANALYSIS OFFICIAL DO-FILE

*=====

***IMPORT RAW DATASET

use "C:\Users\chiar\OneDrive\Desktop\14.05 LAST OFFICIAL STATA
FILES\OFFICIAL_Thesis_survey_Italian (raw dataset).dta", clear

***STEP 0 - RENAMING VARIABLES

*DEMOGRAPHICS

rename Q4 Q4_age_group

rename Q5 Q5_gender

rename Q24 Q24_education

rename Q28 Q28_political_view

*GSJ ITEMS

rename Q5_1 Q5_GSJ_1

rename Q5_2 Q5_GSJ_2

rename Q5_3 Q5_GSJ_3

rename Q5_4 Q5_GSJ_4

rename Q5_5 Q5_GSJ_5

rename Q5_6 Q5_GSJ_6

rename Q5_7 Q5_GSJ_7

rename Q5_8 Q5_GSJ_8

*CORRUPTION PERCEPTION

rename Q9_C_perception_d Q9_corruption_perception

rename Q10_C_perception_i Q10_acceptability

*INTENTIONAL TOLERANCE

rename Q12_Intentional_T_1 Q12_intent_1

rename Q12_Intentional_T_2 Q12_intent_2

rename Q12_Intentional_T_3 Q12_intent_3

rename Q12_Intentional_T_4 Q12_intent_4

*ATTITUDINAL TOLERANCE

rename Q13_Attitudinal_T_1 Q13_attitude_1

rename Q13_Attitudinal_T_2 Q13_attitude_2

rename Q13_Attitudinal_T_3 Q13_attitude_3

rename Q13_Attitudinal_T_4 Q13_attitude_4
```

*PRACTICAL TOLERANCE

rename Q14_Practical_T_1 Q14_practical_1

rename Q14_Practical_T_2 Q14_practical_2

rename Q14_Practical_T_3 Q14_practical_3

rename Q14_Practical_T_4 Q14_practical_4

*BEHAVIOURAL TOLERANCE

rename Q15_Behavioural_T_1 Q15_behaviour_1

rename Q15_Behavioural_T_2 Q15_behaviour_2

rename Q15_Behavioural_T_3 Q15_behaviour_3

rename Q15_Behavioural_T_4 Q15_behaviour_4

*Q17 + Q18

rename Q17 Q17_fight_corruption_belief

rename Q18 Q18_reaction_report

*Q23 ITEMS

rename Q23_1 Q23_support_reason_1

rename Q23_2 Q23_support_reason_2

rename Q23_3 Q23_support_reason_3

rename Q23_4 Q23_support_reason_4

rename Q23_5 Q23_support_reason_5

rename Q23_6 Q23_support_reason_6

rename Q23_7 Q23_support_reason_7

rename Q23_8 Q23_support_reason_8

*****STEP 1 - CHECKS**

describe

summarize

*Structure is clean, scales are consistent, HOWEVER Ns are inconsistent across questions

codebook Q5_GSJ_1 Q5_GSJ_2 Q5_GSJ_3 Q5_GSJ_4 Q5_GSJ_5 Q5_GSJ_6 Q5_GSJ_7 Q5_GSJ_8

*****STEP 2: CREATING GSJ INDEX (=main IV)**

*Reverse coding the negative worded items

gen Q5_GSJ_3_rev = 8 - Q5_GSJ_3

gen Q5_GSJ_7_rev = 8 - Q5_GSJ_7

```

*Create GSJ index (mean)

egen GSJ_index = rowmean(Q5_GSJ_1 Q5_GSJ_2 Q5_GSJ_3_rev ///
                        Q5_GSJ_4 Q5_GSJ_5 Q5_GSJ_6 ///
                        Q5_GSJ_7_rev Q5_GSJ_8)

*Check it

summarize GSJ_index

*reliability

alpha Q5_GSJ_1 Q5_GSJ_2 Q5_GSJ_3_rev ///
      Q5_GSJ_4 Q5_GSJ_5 Q5_GSJ_6 ///
      Q5_GSJ_7_rev Q5_GSJ_8

***STEP 3: CREATING THE CORRUPTION TOLERANCE INDEXES (=main DVs)

* 3.1 - Intentional tolerance

egen corrupt_intent = rowmean(Q12_intent_1 Q12_intent_2 Q12_intent_3 Q12_intent_4)

* 3.2 - attitudinal tolerance

egen corrupt_attitude = rowmean(Q13_attitude_1 Q13_attitude_2 Q13_attitude_3
Q13_attitude_4)

* 3.3 - practical tolerance

egen corrupt_practical = rowmean(Q14_practical_1 Q14_practical_2 Q14_practical_3
Q14_practical_4)

* 3.4 - normative tolerance (using Q10, the moral accpatability question, not how
widespread question)

gen corrupt_normative = Q10_acceptability

*checking them

summarize corrupt_intent corrupt_attitude corrupt_practical corrupt_normative


*Little precision: need to exlcude "don't know" from Q10, otherwise it goes til max
6

tab Q10_acceptability

gen corrupt_normative_clean = Q10_acceptability

replace corrupt_normative_clean = . if corrupt_normative_clean == 6

tab corrupt_normative_clean

summarize corrupt_normative_clean

*Fixing Q9 so that higher values = more perceived corruption

tab Q9_corruption_perception

gen corrupt_diffusion_clean = Q9_corruption_perception

replace corrupt_diffusion_clean = . if corrupt_diffusion_clean == 6

```

```

replace corrupt_diffusion_clean = 6 - corrupt_diffusion_clean if
!missing(corrupt_diffusion_clean)

tab corrupt_diffusion_clean

summarize corrupt_diffusion_clean

*Re running with the "clean" normative tolerance (without "don't know")

summarize corrupt_intent corrupt_attitude corrupt_practical corrupt_normative_clean

* 3.5- Behavioural tolerance (handled separately because different, turned into a
binary variable)

gen corrupt_behavior = .

replace corrupt_behavior = 1 if Q15_behaviour_1 == 1

replace corrupt_behavior = 0 if inlist(Q15_behaviour_1, 2, 3, 4)

replace corrupt_behavior = . if Q15_behaviour_1 == 5

tab corrupt_behavior

summarize corrupt_behavior

***STEP 4: THE NORM-PRACTICE PARADOX --> Do people morally condemn corruption but
still show willingness to engage in it?

* 4.1 Create "moral condemnation" variable : using attitudinal tolerance (Q13) and
creating binary variable (1= condemns corruption) (0= does not strongly condemn
corruption)

gen moral_condemn = .

replace moral_condemn = 1 if corrupt_attitude <= 2

replace moral_condemn = 0 if corrupt_attitude > 2

*check it

tab moral_condemn

*Why threshold = 2? Because: 1 = "not justified at all" 2 = "slightly justified" so
:≤2 = clear rejection

* 4.2 Create "paradox" variable: combining moral_condemn with corrupt_behavior

gen paradox = 0

replace paradox = 1 if moral_condemn == 1 & corrupt_behavior == 1

*the logic: 1 & 1 paradox (condemn but engage)

*check it

tab paradox

*4.3 Cross-tab

```

```

tab moral_condemn corrupt_behavior, row

*this shows how behaviour differs by moral stance

*PROBLEM: current paradox variables includes cases where behaviour is missing (360
vs 224) --> must restrict the analysis to people with both variables

gen paradox_clean = .

replace paradox_clean = 1 if moral_condemn == 1 & corrupt_behavior == 1

replace paradox_clean = 0 if moral_condemn == 1 & corrupt_behavior == 0

*Check it

tab paradox_clean

*cross tab (clean)

tab moral_condemn corrupt_behavior if !missing(corrupt_behavior), row


*4.4 Does GSJ increase or decrease the likelihood of the norm-practice paradox?

*Since the dependent variable is binary (paradox_clean), we use logit:

logit paradox_clean GSJ_index

*4.4.1 marginal effects --> "How much does probability change when GSJ increases by
1 unit"

margins, dydx(GSJ_index)

*4.4.2 Regression with controls (main socio-demographic variables)

logit paradox_clean GSJ_index ///
    i.Q4_age_group i.Q5_gender i.Q28_political_view, vce(robust)


* Calculating substantive effect sizes for the statistically significant models
* SUBSTANTIVE EFFECT: age predicting the norm-practice paradox

logit paradox_clean GSJ_index ///
    i.Q4_age_group i.Q5_gender i.Q28_political_view, vce(robust)


* Get mean and SD of GSJ for the estimation sample

summ GSJ_index if e(sample)

* Get predicted probabilities by age group

margins Q4_age_group

* Compare age groups visually

marginsplot

```

```

*****ATTENTION: Problem found on 14.05

* The original coding classified missing values as 0 because
* Stata treats missing values (.) as larger than numeric values.
* This version is retained for transparency only.

* gen moral_condemn = .
* replace moral_condemn = 1 if corrupt_attitude <= 2
* replace moral_condemn = 0 if corrupt_attitude > 2

* =====
* CORRECTED VERSION
* =====

capture drop moral_condemn
capture drop paradox
capture drop paradox_clean

gen moral_condemn = .
replace moral_condemn = 1 if corrupt_attitude <= 2 ///
    & !missing(corrupt_attitude)
replace moral_condemn = 0 if corrupt_attitude > 2 ///
    & !missing(corrupt_attitude)

gen paradox_clean = .
replace paradox_clean = 1 ///
    if moral_condemn == 1 & corrupt_behavior == 1
replace paradox_clean = 0 ///
    if moral_condemn == 1 & corrupt_behavior == 0

tab moral_condemn
tab moral_condemn corrupt_behavior if !missing(corrupt_behavior), row

*4.4 Does GSJ increase or decrease the likelihood of the norm-practice paradox?
* Since dependent variable is binary
logit paradox_clean GSJ_index

```

```

* Marginal effects
margins, dydx(GSJ_index)

* Controlled model
logit paradox_clean GSJ_index ///
    i.Q4_age_group i.Q5_gender i.Q28_political_view, vce(robust)

* Substantive effects
summ GSJ_index if e(sample)
margins Q4_age_group
marginsplot

***STEP 5: THE PREVALENCE OF CORRUPTION TOLERANCE "TYPES" (descriptive)

tabstat corrupt_attitude corrupt_intent ///
    corrupt_practical corrupt_normative_clean ///
    corrupt_behavior, ///
    statistics(n mean sd min max) columns(statistics)

***STEP 6: CONTEXTUAL DIFFERENCES: Are people more tolerant of corruption in some situations than others?

* 6.1 – Continuous measures (Q12, Q13, Q14) *will compare means across scenarios
summarize Q12_intent_1 Q12_intent_2 Q12_intent_3 Q12_intent_4
summarize Q13_attitude_1 Q13_attitude_2 Q13_attitude_3 Q13_attitude_4
summarize Q14_practical_1 Q14_practical_2 Q14_practical_3 Q14_practical_4

* 6.2 – Behavioral (Q15) → DIFFERENT
foreach v in 1 2 3 4 {
    gen behav`v' = .
    replace behav`v' = 1 if Q15_behaviour_`v' == 1
    replace behav`v' = 0 if inlist(Q15_behaviour_`v', 2, 3, 4)
    replace behav`v' = . if Q15_behaviour_`v' == 5
}

summarize behav1 behav2 behav3 behav4

*STEP 7: CORRUPTION PERCEPTION --> CT : Does perceiving corruption as widespread make people more tolerant of corruption? (*link with literature review)

* 7.1 Bivariate models

*Exploratory correlations
pwcorr corrupt_diffusion_clean ///

```

```

    corrupt_attitude corrupt_intent ///

    corrupt_practical corrupt_normative_clean, sig

*Bivariate regressions

reg corrupt_normative_clean corrupt_diffusion_clean
reg corrupt_attitude corrupt_diffusion_clean
reg corrupt_practical corrupt_diffusion_clean
reg corrupt_intent corrupt_diffusion_clean

logit corrupt_behavior corrupt_diffusion_clean

* 7.2 Adding controls

*Attitudinal

reg corrupt_attitude corrupt_diffusion_clean ///

    i.Q4_age_group i.Q5_gender i.Q24_education i.Q28_political_view, vce(robust)

*Normative

reg corrupt_normative_clean corrupt_diffusion_clean ///

    i.Q4_age_group i.Q5_gender i.Q24_education i.Q28_political_view, vce(robust)

*Intentional

reg corrupt_intent corrupt_diffusion_clean ///

    i.Q4_age_group i.Q5_gender i.Q24_education i.Q28_political_view, vce(robust)

*Practical

reg corrupt_practical corrupt_diffusion_clean ///

    i.Q4_age_group i.Q5_gender i.Q24_education i.Q28_political_view, vce(robust)

** Behavioural model

logit corrupt_behavior corrupt_diffusion_clean ///

    i.Q4_age_group i.Q5_gender i.Q24_education ///

    i.Q28_political_view, vce(robust)

* Marginal effects

margins, dydx(corrupt_diffusion_clean)

* 7.3 Calculating substantive effect sizes for the statistically significant model

** SUBSTANTIVE EFFECT SIZES

* Get mean and SD for corruption perception

```

```

summ corrupt_diffusion_clean if e(sample)

*Predicted values

*margins, at(corrupt_diffusion_clean=(LOW HIGH))

reg corrupt_normative_clean corrupt_diffusion_clean ///

i.Q4_age_group i.Q5_gender i.Q24_education i.Q28_political_view, vce(robust)

margins, at(corrupt_diffusion_clean=(3.26 4.87))

*STEP 8: GSJ --> CT (How does GSJ affect different types of corruption tolerance?)
(MAIN RQ)

* 8.1 Bivariate regressions

*For the continuous dimensions

reg corrupt_attitude GSJ_index

reg corrupt_intent GSJ_index

reg corrupt_practical GSJ_index

reg corrupt_normative_clean GSJ_index

*Behavioral

logit corrupt_behavior GSJ_index

margins, dydx(GSJ_index)

* 8.2 Controlled models

*Attitudinal

reg corrupt_attitude GSJ_index ///

    i.Q4_age_group i.Q5_gender i.Q24_education i.Q28_political_view, vce(robust)

*Intentional

reg corrupt_intent GSJ_index ///

    i.Q4_age_group i.Q5_gender i.Q24_education i.Q28_political_view, vce(robust)

*Practical

reg corrupt_practical GSJ_index ///

    i.Q4_age_group i.Q5_gender i.Q24_education i.Q28_political_view, vce(robust)

*Normative

reg corrupt_normative_clean GSJ_index ///

    i.Q4_age_group i.Q5_gender i.Q24_education i.Q28_political_view, vce(robust)

*Behavioural

```

```

logit corrupt_behavior GSJ_index ///
    i.Q4_age_group i.Q5_gender i.Q24_education i.Q28_political_view, vce(robust)

* 8.3 Calculating substantive effect sizes for statistically significant models
* SUBSTANTIVE EFFECT SIZES

* Normative model: substantive effect of GSJ
reg corrupt_normative_clean GSJ_index ///
    i.Q4_age_group i.Q5_gender i.Q24_education i.Q28_political_view, vce(robust)
margins, at(GSJ_index=(2.05 3.79))

* Intentional model: predicted values by age group
reg corrupt_intent GSJ_index ///
    i.Q4_age_group i.Q5_gender i.Q24_education i.Q28_political_view, vce(robust)

tab Q4_age_group if e(sample)
margins Q4_age_group

* Practical model: predicted values by age group
reg corrupt_practical GSJ_index ///
    i.Q4_age_group i.Q5_gender i.Q24_education i.Q28_political_view, vce(robust)

tab Q4_age_group if e(sample)
margins Q4_age_group

***STEP 9: WHO SCORES HIGH ON GSJ? --> on the dispositional factors affecting GSJ
* 9.1 Descriptive differences
tabstat GSJ_index, by(Q4_age_group) stats(mean sd n)
tabstat GSJ_index, by(Q5_gender) stats(mean sd n)
tabstat GSJ_index, by(Q24_education) stats(mean sd n)
tabstat GSJ_index, by(Q28_political_view) stats(mean sd n)

*since political orienataion variable is very skewed, its recoded into binary
variable (include only prgressive vs moderate (conservatives are dropped))
gen pol_progressive = .

```

```

replace pol_progressive = 1 if inlist(Q28_political_view, 1, 2)    // progressive
replace pol_progressive = 0 if Q28_political_view == 3           // moderate
replace pol_progressive = . if inlist(Q28_political_view, 4, 5, 6)

* 9.2 Regression
reg GSJ_index pol_progressive ///
    i.Q4_age_group i.Q5_gender i.Q24_education, vce(robust)

* DIGRESSION
* Check variables
describe GSJ_index ResponseId Q4_age_group Q5_gender ///
Q6 Q24_education Q26 Q28_political_view

* TOP 5 HIGHEST AND LOWEST GSJ RESPONDENTS
* Top 5 highest GSJ
gsort -GSJ_index
list ResponseId GSJ_index Q4_age_group Q5_gender ///
Q6 Q24_education Q26 Q28_political_view in 1/5
browse in 1/5

* Top 5 lowest GSJ
gsort GSJ_index
list ResponseId GSJ_index Q4_age_group Q5_gender ///
Q6 Q24_education Q26 Q28_political_view in 1/5
browse in 1/5

* EXPLORATORY : GSJ AND HOUSEHOLD INCOME
* Descriptive means
mean GSJ_index, over(Q26)

* Visualization
graph bar (mean) GSJ_index, over(Q26) ///
    title("Mean GSJ by income category") ///
    ytitle("Mean GSJ index")

* Main categorical model

```

```

reg GSJ_index i.Q26

* Exploratory overall trend test

pwcorr GSJ_index Q26, sig

reg GSJ_index c.Q26

***STEP 10: ANTI-CORRUPTION ACTION: Does system justification influence anti-
corruption engagement?

*Check dependent varibale (q18)

tab Q18_reaction_report

*Regression

reg Q18_reaction_report GSJ_index ///
    i.Q4_age_group i.Q5_gender i.Q24_education i.pol_progressive, vce(robust)

*After beginning the Qual analysis, I wonder if younger respondents are more likely
to be hopeless and show resignation. I use two of my closed ended qquestions Q17
and Q18, to create a "resignation index" and test it by age

**!! OLD VERSION: kept for transparency

*A)Reverse Q18

*gen Q18_rev = 6 - Q18

*B)Create index

*egen resignation_index = rowmean(Q17 Q18_rev)

*C)Test Age

*reg resignation_index i.Q4_age_group, vce(robust)

*Adding controls

*reg resignation_index i.Q4_age_group i.Q5_gender i.Q24_education
i.pol_progressive, vce(robust)

*CORRECTED VERSION

* Remove old versions

capture drop Q17_rescaled

capture drop Q18_rev

capture drop resignation_index

* Rescale Q17 from 3-point to 5-point scale

gen Q17_rescaled = .

replace Q17_rescaled = 1 if Q17_fight_corruption_belief == 1

```

```

replace Q17_rescaled = 3 if Q17_fight_corruption_belief == 2
replace Q17_rescaled = 5 if Q17_fight_corruption_belief == 3
* Reverse Q18 so higher values = greater resignation
gen Q18_rev = 6 - Q18_reaction_report
* Create corrected resignation index
egen resignation_index = rowmean(Q17_rescaled Q18_rev)

* Check
summ resignation_index

* Re-run regressions
reg resignation_index i.Q4_age_group, vce(robust)
reg resignation_index i.Q4_age_group ///
    i.Q5_gender i.Q24_education ///
    i.pol_progressive, vce(robust)

***STEP 11: ASSESING SALIENCE OF ALTERNATIVE EXPLANATIONS

*Calculate frequencies for each option
foreach var of varlist Q23_support_reason_* {
    tab `var'
}

***SAVING UPDATETD DATSET

save "C:\Users\chiar\OneDrive\Desktop\14.05 LAST OFFICIAL STATA
FILES\OFFICIAL_Thesis_survey_Italian_cleaned.dt

```